

Block**4****DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION: MODELS AND THEORIES**

UNIT 13**Communication: Concepts and Process**

UNIT 14**Models of Communication**

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UNIT 13 COMMUNICATION: CONCEPT AND PROCESS

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13.0 INTRODUCTION

What exactly is communication? The word is derived from the Latin word ‘communis’ which means ‘to make common’. Communication, at the simplest level, involves understanding what someone conveys and means and in turn making someone else understand what you mean. However, for communication to take place, it is important for some basic understanding to exist, which is possible only when the two people feel and think about that subject on common lines. The more the commonness between two people, the better their communication gets. In the parlance of communication, the person who sends a message or communicates is called *Sender/ Source* and the one who receives it is called the *Receiver*. A well-known media expert, Denis McQuail in his book “Mass Communication Theory” defined communication as:

“The process that increases commonality but also requires elements of commonality to occur at all.”

Many social scientists have attempted to define communication from different perspectives. One of the oldest and most widely quoted one is from a western political scientist, Harold Lasswell (1948) who posed some questions the answers to which would have communication defined. He described it as:

“Who says what in which channel to whom with what effect?”

Channel here stands for the medium of communication which may be language, book or even a mass medium like radio, television or newspaper. The effect is the common understanding that communication aims at building. According to

John C. Merrill and Ralph L. Lowenstein, communication is:

“A meeting of minds, a bringing about of a common set of symbols in the minds of participants – in short, an understanding.”

13.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit you will be able to:

- analyse communication, its process and need;
- describe forms of communication and effective communication;
- development of communications media;
- differentiate between conventional and new media; and
- interpret how the media plays a role in social construction of reality.

13.2 UNDERSTANDING OF DEVELOPMENT AND PROGRESS

Communication is as important a need for all living beings as is food and shelter. And all living beings invariably communicate within their community, be it the evening call of the birds to return back to their homes or barking of dogs in protest when a non-member enters their territory or the dance of the honeybees to convey to other members where nectar can be found. For human beings too, this is a natural individual and social need as man is a social animal. No normal human being can exist in isolation, irrespective of his age, gender and interests.

13.2.1 Communication Process

Communication leads to creation of meaning that gets shared between the participants as a continuous, cyclic process. What the sender shares with the receiver is knowledge or information based on his own individual experiences. What the sender understands as an outcome of those experiences is what he further conveys to the receiver. So, one common functional definition for communication can be:

“A cyclic process of sharing of experiences between two or more participants”

This brings us to the process of communication. The process of communication involves four basic elements – the sender (S), the message (M), the channel (C) and the receiver (R) – what is also called the SMCR model of communication. The representation below (Fig.1.1) indicates how communication which takes place in a cyclic process: diagram

The sender initiates communication by sending a message and the receiver or the audience is/are the one(s) who receives it, message is the actual content that the sender desires to convey and channel is the medium of conveying that message. Channel, the medium of conveying the message can be mass media, language, gestures, body language, signs and symbols. When the sender sends a message through some channel to the receiver, the receiver decodes that message in his brain, makes meaning out of it (interpreting) and then encodes the response of that message in his mind and conveys it back to the sender. This process of conveying back is called feedback, an important component in the process of

communication. Feedback indicates whether what has been understood is what the source/sender meant or is it different from the source's understanding. While receiving the feedback, the sender becomes the receiver and the receiver becomes the sender.

13.2.2 Effective Communication

A communication is considered effective if it produces the desired results. For example, if a political leader through his speech is able to motivate the electorate to cast their votes for him, his communication may be termed as effective. Alternately, a child tends to take the warning or instructions of his parents or teachers seriously but will not listen to a stranger. His parents' communication to him is effective but the latter is not. From both the examples it is clear that it is the relationship between the source and the receiver that communicates, it is this factor that decides how the meaning would be interpreted at the receiver's end. The perception of the source by the receiver or the trust factor that exists in their relationship decides how positively the receiver would respond to the source's message. Any communication is called effective if the meaning of the message interpreted by the receiver is the same as that desired by the sender. The effectiveness of the message would be clear from whether or to what extent any desired behavioral change is brought about in the receiver. This is also termed as feedback which can be in words and/or actions. The response that a communication message emanates in the receiver is termed as feedback. Feedback may be positive, negative or neutral. When an employee continues to come late to office despite repeated reminders, it is a negative feedback as the communication is not having the desired response on the employee. When a student makes all efforts to meet the assignment deadlines of a teacher, it is a positive feedback as it is the result of the high regard the student may have towards the teacher and hence the teacher's communication is termed effective. When a voter does not exercise his right to vote, leave alone voting in favour of or against a political leader, then it is called a neutral feedback as the communication did not have any effect on him.

13.2.3 Barriers to Communication

There are certain barriers to communication which may hinder its effectiveness. These may be of varied types:

- Communicating to the receiver at a wrong/inconvenient time.
- The message communicated is distorted (i.e. change in the meaning of the message due to noise) some reason. Noise is termed as the change that is introduced in the message so that its meaning does not remain what was intended by the source. Information overload is yet another barrier as every individual has a limited attention span during which he/she is receptive to communication messages.

Besides technical barriers, there are also language and psychological barriers to communication. Language barriers may be of two kinds:

- Vocabulary (use of difficult words that the receiver may not understand)
- Semantics (when the meaning of the message is not clear to the audience or what the audience understands is different from what the source meant).

- Psychological barriers may include these factors:
- Noise: Sometimes when the student in the class is thinking of an India-Pakistan cricket match that is to take place that evening, what the teacher is talking may be noise to him. Alternatively, any disturbance in the frequency of a radio channel can create disturbance and the audience may not be able to hear what is being broadcast.
- Perception set differences: Over a period of time, individuals build a certain tendency to perceive a message in a certain way. For example, some people believe what advertisements claim about a certain product as their experiences with it may be positive. Alternately, there may be others who may not believe such messages as their experiences with the same product/service may not be satisfactory. This tendency is called perception set. Due to differences in experiences, value systems, beliefs and social realities of individuals, differences in perception set will always exist due to which a message may not have the same effect on all individuals.
- Lack of trust and jealousy: These may also be the reasons why a message may not have the desired effect on the audience.
- Information filtering: The receivers have a tendency to accept only those messages that they find are of interest to them or reinforce the notions and beliefs that they already have. They filter such information and leave out the rest thereby becoming another psychological barrier.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Describe the process of communication.

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2) Explain the barriers to communication.

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13.3 FORMS OF COMMUNICATION

Having known what communication is what makes it effective and what reduces its effective capacity, it is also important to know the different forms in which

this process is carried out. Though we are exposed to each of these forms in our daily lives, we may have never paid any attention to it. Communication scholars agree that there are four basic forms of communication:

- **Intrapersonal communication:** This is the kind of communication in which there is only one participant who is the sender as well as the receiver. This is also known as auto communication or introspection. Talking to oneself is a good example for this.
- **Interpersonal communication:** This communication takes place between two participants and the exchange may be formal or informal. It is the most ideal kind of communication as the sender can get feedback instantly and as it is one to one communication, the sender can also study the body language (gestures, postures, facial expressions etc.) of the receiver which gives ample idea of what the receiver means and whether what is said is also what is meant. Influencing and persuading the other person is also easy and there is greater scope of appealing to the receiver emotionally by means of motivating, encouraging and coordinating. It is also known as dyadic communication.
- **Group communication:** This is an extension of interpersonal communication and the exchange involves more than two people where the participants get a chance to express themselves on subjects of common interests. This communication serves many goals like collective decision making, self-expression, and relaxation and is effective as it gives opportunity to interact directly with the receivers. One common aspect of such a communication is that it sees the emergence of a leader who coordinates the communication within the group.
- **Mass communication:** This is the communication that takes place with the help of a mechanical device that multiplies messages and takes it to a large faceless audience simultaneously. The use of mass media like newspaper, radio, television and internet is needed in this kind of communication. The source and the receiver are physically separated in time and space. The audience is anonymous and heterogeneous. The feedback in mass communication is slow, weak and delayed.

Different forms of the above mentioned communication are effective in different communication contexts. The widest reach is of mass communication but the most effective is interpersonal communication. For example, to make the general public aware of a new product, advertisements and publicity are the best ways for which use of mass media is mandatory. On the other hand, for a desired change in an individual's behavior like quitting smoking, it is more fruitful to counsel him personally, i.e. interpersonal communication would be more effective.

13.4 DEVELOPMENT OF COMMUNICATION MEDIA

When there were less communication and communication channels in the society, people lived on the basis of equality as there was no hierarchy among people.

Later, those who controlled the channels of communication emerged stronger while the others were weak. With changing times and technology, the

communications media developed as people realised the subtle though strong effect media could have in influencing public opinion. In the earlier societies, it was the number of women a man had that determined his status in the society. Later, the number of cattle one owned was indicative of one's status. Even later, it was how much land one had that determined it and then it was the riches that counted most. These stages of societal development on the basis of economic development are identified as:

- **Pre agricultural societies:** There were small communities that existed with mostly spoken words as their means of communication and comprised of hunters and food gatherers.
- **Agricultural societies:** People practised agriculture to earn their living, writing came into being and these were more developed societies with a complex social structure. But a huge chunk of the population still remained illiterate.
- **Industrial societies:** This was the machine age and was marked by the publication of Gutenberg's Bible in as early as 1455. This drastically improved the speed of book printing that was earlier copied by hand, by the use of movable metal type. Mass production became the mantra and industrial production was centered in cities which led to huge migration of people from rural to urban areas. Jobs in these industries became more important than farming.
- **Information society:** The second half of 1900s saw the emergence of information societies primarily in the United States. But from the second half of the century till its end, most economies of the world had drifted towards it because of which media became much more important than before. One important invention of the time was computers that became the main tool to handle information, its creation, processing and distribution.

Today information is power. Those who have better sources of information are more resourceful and stronger in society; they are the opinion leaders and are listened to while others do not wield such a control. The information society has also seen different conventional media forms merging together into one, thus becoming cheaper, more accessible and faster. The conventional media forms that comprised different communication technologies merged together into a computer readable digital form. The earlier technologies were analogous or linear in nature while digital technologies could be stored and used in any format and were easy to use. This process of merging of technologies to give better output of more than one conventional media technology is called 'convergence'. For example, a mobile phone serves the purpose of a phone as well as a computer as emails can be accessed on it and the internet can be browsed. Also, a computer acts as television as channels can be accessed on it. Television and computers on the other hand have made DVD players outdated. All these examples show how the output of more than one technology can be had from a more compact and cheaper technology. Also these technologies are interactive which makes feedback an inclusive process of communication. It enables the improvement of messages. This fast exchange of information through cyber networks has led to coining of the term *information superhighway* irrespective of the communication objective which may be social networking, e commerce, e governance or professional communication.

Before we delve further into this discussion of the twenty-first century technology, let us take a view of the characteristic features of conventional media that dominated the communication media scene for long and the new media that has lately emerged.

- **Newspapers:** The ancestors of newspapers were called Corantos which were news sheets that were published as long back as 1620s in England and Holland with irregular periodicity. Later, around 1640s, Diurnals appeared in England that were dailies publishing reports on domestic events. They were the actual ancestors of the newspapers we see today. At present, we have two formats in which newspapers appear: broadsheets (for example, The Indian Express, The Times of India) and tabloids (for example Mail Today and Mint). Broadsheets are the morningers that carry hard news and opinions based on them while most tabloids are evenings or evening papers that are more of news magazines or feature newspapers. While broadsheets come up with fresh news, tabloids carry features and detailed stories based on them. While the advantage of newspapers is that they sell cheap, they can reach out only to the literate section of the population. Over the last six to seven years, a lot of experimentation has been done in Indian newspapers from reducing their sizes in order to make them portable to dividing them into as many sections as can be covered in order to cater to maximum number of readers. Innovations are also brought out to market them as a product and as a viewpoint. While their circulation is dying out in the West, in India, they are soaring high.
- **Magazines:** The earliest magazine was published in England in the 1730s. Though they primarily focused on politics, they were then called miscellanies as they carried a wide variety of contents. In the later part of the 1800s, magazines made efforts for popularising magazine reading. And there was a widespread growth due to increase in literacy, reduced costs to ensure greater sales and because in that era of industrialisation, more and more businesses wanted a platform to put forth their advertisements and publicity messages. Today, magazines are generally classified into general interest and special interest magazines. The first category is of those magazines that cover a number of subjects to cater to wider masses (for example, India Today, Outlook) and the second category is the one that caters to a niche audience (for example, Better Photography, National Geographic and Business World). Most newspaper groups own the magazines that one generally sees on the newsstands. The reason that when the ad flow increases the newspaper's capacity to publish also increases. Newspaper groups come up with sister concerns in the form of magazines that have longer shelf life and hence make advertisement publication a costlier affair.
- **Radio:** Radio was first invented by an Italian named Marconi in the 1890s. He is called the 'Father of Radio'. Broadcasting, or transmitting voices and music to a geographically separated large audience had begun through the telephone itself which was invented by Alexander Graham Bell before the advent of radio. That is when radio became a mass medium. In India, the first license for transmitting a broadcast was given in February 1922 while the AIR was formed in June 1936. The most important time in the history of radio was during the Second World War when this medium of addressing the masses became immensely significant. This was because the Nazis in

Germany used it for propaganda and by playing German music which would give an impression that they had conquered the areas where the music was played, they could damage the morale of their rival forces. FM broadcasts first started in Chennai (then Madras) in 1977 and in Jalandhar (Punjab) in 1992. Private players came into the picture only in 1993. Radio later developed into a youth medium. Today, radio's approach is more local in nature, right from giving traffic updates to playing popular music. The advantage of this medium is that it is mobile, does not require reading ability and can be enjoyed without demanding sole attention on the medium itself (unlike television). These days, the emergence of community radio is seen in large numbers which makes more specialized programmes for a niche audience.

- **Television:** Television first started developing in the 1920s and 1930s. After the printing press, television is considered to be the most important communication invention. By the late 1940s and early 1950s, television had become a part of life in most of the developed countries. In India, television was introduced with the objective of bringing about development in the year 1959. By 1970, the content on TV included news, information and entertainment programmes including 'Krishi Darshan' which began in January 1967 for farmers in 80 villages. Commercials were first telecast in January 1976. Today, the number of television channels in India outnumber the time one can afford to spend watching them even once a week. The race for TRPs (Television Rating Points) which decide the popularity of a TV show or a channel is of prime importance as it directly affects the ad revenue that the channel earns. In fact, for the very reason, channels do not mind compromising on work ethics or building an agenda for public discussion for their vested interests. 24 hour news channels have become a reality with no sanctity of what should be called news. In fact, television creates reality that may sometimes not be real. For example, the portrayal of superwomen in Indian media- one who can single handedly carry out all tasks in personal, professional and social life without faltering at any point of time is the one who is termed the ideal Indian modern woman.
- **Cinema:** The earliest cinema was a portrayal of real event shots in motion without any sound, story line or plot. They were just black and white larger than life size silent scenes that first came up as early as 1896. The first Indian movie is said to be '*Raja Harishchandra*' which too was a silent movie made in the year 1913 by one of the pioneers of Indian cinema, Dadasaheb Phalke. The first talkie (film that could talk) in India was Alam Ara made in 1931. In the years to come, regional cinema also flourished. Contemporary films have not just remained a form of art for its lovers to delight in, they have also started taking up contemporary issues which makes for both entertainment and food for thought. The relationship of cinema with society is very complex. It has been found to have an effect on the psychology of the audience while the degree of audience acceptability has varied from one film to another looking at their experimental nature and low investments over the past four to five years. While romance, comedy and depiction of real life situations click with the audience most of the time while horror films are much less accepted. The Central Board of Film Certification in India looks into matters of what can go to the larger masses and what may disturb their sensibilities. Following a certain 'Code of Ethics,'

they either allow or censor objectionable scenes in a film. Also, based on whether they can affect the minds of the more impressionable section of the society, the films are certified as 'U' or universal (meant for all age groups) and 'A' or adult (meant for people only above 18 years of age).

- **Folk media:** This medium has been alive in our society since ancient times and has been used for conveying political, social and moral messages. The advantage of such a medium is that it is personalised (members of the same community perform it) and is used where the audience fully accepts it which makes the communication effective. It relates to all age groups of people and is inexpensive. Mainly confined to rural India, this is special in every part of the country. For example, Tamasha and Pawala in Maharashtra, Yakshagana in Karnataka, Jatra in Bengal, Bhavai in Gujarat and Nautanki, Ramlila and Raslila in the northern states of India. They may be satirical or sharp in their messages sometimes but are efficient tools of communication. Many NGOs also make use of these forms considering how powerful a medium it is. Government bodies in rural areas also make use of folk media to pass on health or agriculture or any other development issue related messages that are smartly imbibed in traditional folk songs, dances and mythological stories. That is what makes it a powerful tool of development communication.

So far we discussed the conventional media; the new media is the internet. Let's see how it has revolutionised the world.

- **Internet:** The first calculator, 'abacus' was the predecessor of the computer which was first used by Egyptians in 460 B.C. Some scholars also mention the Chinese abacus. Charles Babbage, an Englishman is called the father of computer who first produced designs for a computer that could make calculations based on stored memory. The internet as we know it today has fast developed to replace and merge most communication devices and technologies. Today, they are used in educational institutions, commercial and business organisations, government departments, international organisations and the defence sector. But these are the major sectors, it has made its inroads even into the lives of most individuals and made them have an internet identity. Virtual reality has almost become literal with the kind of involvement it has in our day to day lives. It has most evident advantages but also perils that stand out from the rest. While social networking has helped in building interpersonal connections in far and distant lands for personal and professional reasons without spending as much as a penny, it has also led to anti-social and aggressive behavior on the net. For example, writing hate mails about personalities, organisations and religions, defaming and harassing people by posting morphed photographs or posting nasty things by hacking their accounts and different kinds of cyber crimes like hacking bank accounts and even child molesters contacting children through chat rooms. Whatever its dangers, the internet has taken the world by storm and there is no stopping it. Moreover, as referred to earlier, each individual conventional medium has computer related technology to operate it. As all TV and radio has turned to digital from analogous, printing has become cheaper by the aid of computers in the form of desktop printing. Newspapers and magazines use computers for designing and editing, there are e books and e music available at the click of a mouse and films and videos use this technology too.

So far, we have understood what mass communication means, how mass media developed and what are the special features and characteristics of different media forms, both conventional and new media. Now let us analyse the conventional and contemporary views of mass media.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What are the different types of communication?

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2) Information is power-elaborate.

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3) Identify the different media categories.

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13.5 MASS COMMUNICATION: THE CONVENTIONAL VIEW

To make the study of the conventional and contemporary view simple, let us try to analyse communication through its characteristics and economics.

Conventional Communication characteristics: The conventional view of mass communication considered media to be all powerful. The communication was made from a single source to anonymous and heterogeneous multitudes of audience irrespective of their tastes, interests and preferences. The audience was considered passive who would accept anything served to them by the media. A few controllers of media through their media empires decided what should and should not go into the public domain or what should be the public agenda; they were instrumental in creating tastes and opinions of the audiences. So they not only acted as gatekeepers in the media but also helped in setting the media's agenda. These functions are called the gatekeeping *and agenda setting* functions of media respectively. While the messages were undifferentiated (i.e. same for

all audiences alike), the motive was to create some kind of consensus among all by creating similar tastes and viewpoints. The feedback to such a communication was negligible and was not given much importance.

Conventional media economics: Alongside these characteristics, the economics of media also toed a different line. You all know that the media get their revenues from advertising. Larger the circulation of newspapers and greater the television rating points (TRPs) for television channels, more profitable will be the business. In such a conventional system, media required as many audiences as they could possibly get to generate revenue through advertising. The audience was not systematically targeted as it was not differentiated according to market needs.

13.6 MASS COMMUNICATION: THE CONTEMPORARY VIEW

Contemporary Communication: Convergence has been phenomenal in defining the contemporary view of mass communication as we know it today. Convergence is the phenomenon of merging technologies and producing more than one different kind of output while also making its use simpler. Convergence along with further technological innovations made the media market consumer-oriented. With the onset of 24 hours news channels and numerous entertainment channels, more magazines and newspapers, more FM channels on radio, there was a huge variety of content for the consumer to pick and choose from. There was something for all segments of audience, be they housewives, children, adults or people who looked for serious news and opinions. This gave the media consumers the liberty to form their own opinion and created competition among various media platforms (inter media competition like that between print and electronic media) as well as the media groups owning similar media segments (intra media competition like between different newspapers). Meanwhile, control shifted into the hands of the consumer who became spoilt for choice and wielded control by simply zapping channels or choosing to change the newspaper that came to his house. Also, while technology became an easy to use product, consumers also found themselves becoming the producers of content. For example, they could now create their own websites or blogs, create their own movies and upload them too for everyone to see. Citizen journalism is another case in point. As they were the producers as well as consumers of media communication, they came to be called prosumers.

Media economics: There was a greater focus on media marketing innovations, with media enticing the audience by various ways to opt for their product. Price war ensued between media organisations and every media tried to slash their prices as much as they could while aiming to build on their circulation/TRPs. Every medium started marketing itself like any other usable commodity, say, soap or shampoos. Media also collaborate with products or services other than media to sell themselves. Most of the organisations wanted to own more media platforms, for example, a newspaper also owned a radio channel, a TV channel, an event management company and a news agency. This not only benefited in creating monopolies in the markets they operated in but also helped in creating a self-sufficient support system for all their media platforms. But what was more, they were in a better position to negotiate with their advertisers with better offers and packages. The media companies today are ready to pirouette as per audience demands, encourage audience participation and feedback while also aiming at profit maximisation.

13.7 ROLE OF MEDIA AND SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF REALITY

Media were earlier instrumental in creating public opinion the way they desired and continue to influence it in contemporary times as well. Media cannot be counted as less powerful even now. There are certain changes that media bring about in a subtle manner which the audience does not consciously realise until the society where these media operate is high on the media literacy scale. Unfortunately for India, this is not the case. There are a number of reasons for this such as varying demographics, cultures, religions, buying capacities, exposure levels, et al. But before that, let us try and understand what social construction of reality means and how the media create it.

Social construction of reality is the portrayal of reality presented to the audience as the media see it. It is a kind of distorted reality presented by the media with a certain agenda to promote, be it in terms of profit making through sensationalism, certain portrayal of a given section of the society or stereotyping modern women by some pre-defined moral and cultural societal values and norms. To understand this better, consider a few examples. A number of advertisements on the Indian television channels talk about fairness creams and their measurable effectiveness for both men and women in order to help them look attractive. Unconsciously, fairness has become one of the parameters of beauty in India. Media have promoted it and people have, due to the subtle influence that message reinforcement creates over the years, accepted it for generations now. Let us look at some more examples. A modern Indian woman is pictured in the media as one who is more of a superwoman – one who handles the responsibilities of the family and profession successfully and errorless, she cooks well, dresses well and wins over in board meetings, she is morally upright, and she is a loving mom and a dutiful housewife and never falters in any role. Such a portrayal is never practically possible but Indian media depicts her as a blend of traditionalism and modernity and this is how a modern Indian woman is perceived by the public at large. This perceived reality through which the media give role models to society or create images of different realities is the social construction of reality. We call it ‘social’ construction because we as a culture believe it to be true. That is why media theorists believe that *‘reality is not what is real, reality is what is perceived.’* Communication consists of signs and symbols. Communication scientists believe that while objective meanings are attached to symbols, for example, a red light at a traffic signal means the same to everyone, signs are more complex to comprehend as they may mean differently to different people. They have subjective meanings

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What do you understand by media convergence?

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2) How do you view the media construction of reality?

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13.8 LET US SUM UP

Media never promised to work for philanthropy though they were created to be socially responsible. It remained on us, the audience to stay aware of the kind of content that it was offering and select/ reject it collectively. Initially, the statesmen of the country wanted to see the media strong on both national and regional levels as the objectives for which they were planned were different. But once this entity became powerful, it diverted its focus to suit its needs. Now the society looks for someone with whom the buck would rest. But, the truth is that nobody can/will solely shoulder the responsibility. Only the audience denouncing malpractices of the media and introducing synthetic value systems in Indian society can bring about a change in what is being served to the audience in the name of news, entertainment and role models. Change always takes long and is never easy. The future holds hope. What remains to be seen is whether or not our media with the people would be able to meet the challenge.

13.9 KEYWORDS

Communication : Exchange of information

Conventional media : Media like newspapers, magazines radio and television

Convergence: Combining of technologies to make it consumer-friendly in the media market

New media : Internet based media

Mediated reality: Media construction of reality that is different from what exists in the society

13.10 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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13.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The sender sends the message to a receiver through a channel. When the receiver transmits his reaction to the sender it is called feedback. The communication can be verbal or non-verbal.
- 2) The barriers to effective communication are: Inconvenient timing, information overload, Technical issues in the form of physical noise, language- vocabulary and semantics and psychological noise in the form of perceptual differences, lack of trust, jealousy and information filtering.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) The different types of communication are intra-personal, interpersonal, group and mass communication.
- 2) People who have better sources of information are more resourceful, rich and strong in any society for that matter. They wield power and control. Others respect them
- 3) The conventional media are newspapers and magazines, radio and television besides cinema and folk media. The new media are internet-based media platforms. The other classifications are: Print media- newspapers and magazines, electronic media- radio and television, in addition to folk media and new media. Often films fall into their own category.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Convergence means merging of technologies and producing more than one kind one different kind of output. It makes the media content use simple and the media market consumer friendly. The mobile phone can be your radio, TV and internet besides being a phone.

Social construction of reality means the portrayal of reality presented to the audience the way the media looks at it. It can be a distorted reality presented by the media with a certain agenda to promote. The agenda can be to make more profit through sensationalism or it can be stereotyping of certain classes of society.

UNIT 14 MODELS OF COMMUNICATION

Structure

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- 14.4 Osgood and Schramm's Models
- 14.5 Berlo's Model
- 14.6 Gerbner's Model
- 14.7 Newcomb's Model
- 14.8 Westley and Maclean's Model
- 14.9 Jakobson's Model
- 14.10 A Critique of Transmission Perspective
- 14.11 Let Us Sum Up
- 14.12 Keywords
- 14.13 References and Further Readings
- 14.14 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

14.0 INTRODUCTION

In this unit we will study various models of communication. With their help, we will try to understand the process of communication with various steps and stages. We will start with some basic communication models and then move to the more complex models of communication. Along With them, we will uncover various concepts of noise, feedback, context, shared experience and equilibrium.

We will further discuss how these concepts affect and impact the process of communication and effectiveness of a message. Towards the end of the unit, we will try to critique the perspective adopted by these models and explore other ways of understanding the process of communication from other angles.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- explain why we need models to understand communication;
- describe the basic and more complex models;
- discuss how these models are relevant in the contemporary social and media environment;
- enumerate the basic elements that are an essential requirement (SMCR) for communication and understand the interrelationship between these different elements;
- explain how these models can be applied to interpersonal communication and which of these models are useful to better understand mass communication; and

- understand and critique the notion of ‘transmission perspective’ in communication models.

14.2 COMMUNICATION MODELS

Communication is a complex process, involving many stages, many participants, formation and consumption of a message. Communication studies use communication Models to understand and discuss the process of communication. Now the question arises why communication models?

Models visualise the process of communication. In other words we are able to understand the communication process by representing it in a graphic form. Models are thus abstractions of larger and complex processes and ideas of communication. They should be seen as maps that guide us to better understand human as well as technology driven communication. Some models are more detailed than others, while others are more basic and rudimentary. As the communication studies as a paradigm evolved, so did the attempts at learning and depicting the process.

According to **Harold Lasswell**, (1948) a convenient way to describe an act of communication is to answer these questions:

- Who
- Says what
- In which channel
- To whom
- With what effect

If we focus on this model carefully we can observe that the emphasis has been placed on the effect of communication on the receiver. The whole process is understood as a means of creating an effect on the receiver by ‘transmitting’ some information. Its quality is judged by the end result, which in this case is if the message was accepted favourably. Let us look at some other variations of transmission models.

14.3 SHANNON AND WEAVER’S MATHEMATICAL MODEL OF COMMUNICATION

Our journey began at the Bell Telephone laboratories where Shannon and Weaver worked on the mathematical model of communication. They were not social science researchers but engineers working on the process of communication. Let us look at this model as given in Figure 14.1:

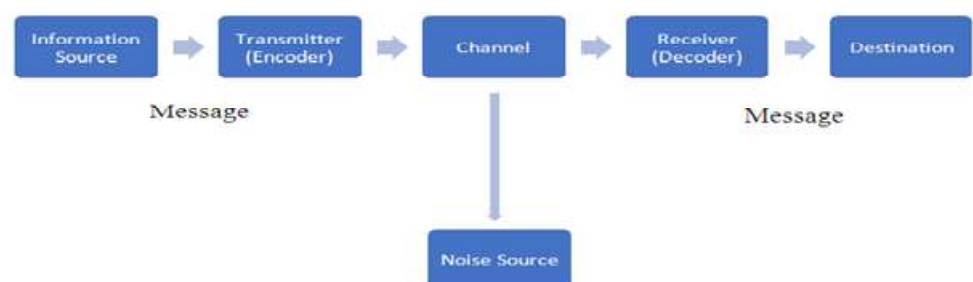


Fig 14.1

In this linear model of communication, Shannon and Weaver have tried to understand and describe the process of communication by taking cues from the telephone system. Their main concern is to look for the most efficient way to use a channel of communication to transmit a maximum amount of information from the source to the destination. In this process of communication the message that originates with the source is transformed into a signal by the transmitter; this signal is then sent across to the receiver through the channel and finally reaches the destination. In a telephone system the channel is the telephone cable, the signal the electric current and the transmitter and receiver are the telephone instruments. Because of the way, this model has been conceptualised, it's also known as the engineering model of communication. According to John Fiske, Shannon and Weaver's mathematical understanding of communication is based on the premise that accuracy and efficiency are the key concerns for effective communication. In doing so Shannon and Weaver assumed that efficient communication can best convey desired meaning or enable semantic accuracy.

Q: What is semantics?

A: Semantics is about understanding how meaning is attached to words. These meanings have extra linguistic connections and are rooted in our culture. For example while we use the word '**Lift**' in North America, the prevalent usage is of the word '**Elevator**', a machine that takes us to the upper floors of a high rise building. Through this example we can see that efficiency and accuracy in the transmission of messages are not sufficient categories for understanding effective communication. We need to go deeper to understand the area of 'meaning making' to complicate these ideas.

The most important aspect of Shannon and Weaver's model is the concept of **noise**, which can hinder the process of effective communication. "Noise is something that gets added to the signal between its transmission and reception that is not intended by the source," (Fiske: 1982). In other words, noise is an unwanted signal that gets added and creates a hindrance in the transmission of the intended message, making the process of decoding of the message much harder. This hindrance could be in the form of a physical noise, like a booming microphone, a noisy ceiling fan, a blaring loudspeaker or just static in the telephone connection.

But there are other ways also in which we can conceptualise noise. Semantic noise would occur even when the transmission of the message is accurate and efficient, but is unable to transmit the intended meaning. Can you think of any real world examples where someone says something very eloquently, but is misread by the intended audience? Shannon and Weaver also argued that there could be three levels of problems in this suggested model of communication:

- **The technical problem:** Where there is a problem in the channel or decoding. This will affect the accuracy of the message. For e.g. if the pages of this book are torn, or the ink is illegible, you may not understand what is written.
- **The semantic problem:** Where there is a discrepancy in the meaning understood by the receiver. For e.g. if you do not understand English, reading and comprehending this text would be impossible.
- **The effectivity problem:** Where there is a question of the message being received, comprehended, but still not effective. Many social messages fail to work as they do not bring about the intended change in the behaviour of

14.4 OSGOOD AND SCHRAMM'S MODEL OF COMMUNICATION

Charles E. Osgood (1954) developed a model in which the sender and the receiver enter into a dynamic relationship with each other in the process of communication. The process according to them is bilateral instead of being unilateral and is equally important.

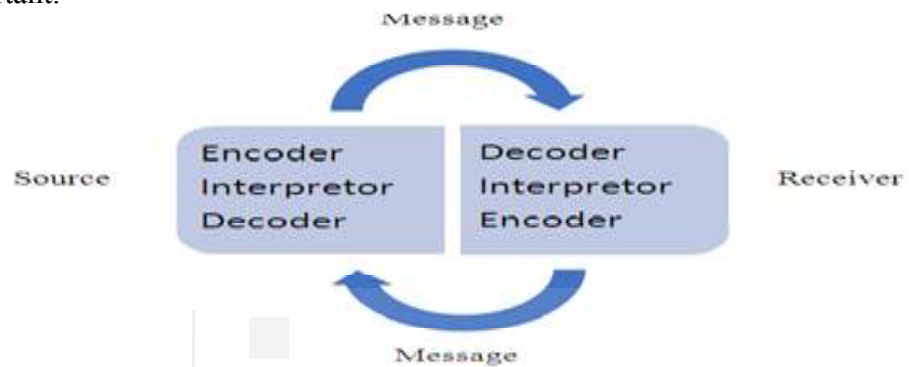


Fig 14.2

In this model the source or the sender encodes a message which gets decoded and interpreted by the receiver. But the process does not end here. Now it is the receiver's turn to encode a message and send it to the source. This message is now decoded and interpreted by the source. The strength of this model is that it looks at communication as a far more dynamic and interactive process in which both the source and receiver or A and B participate by responding to each other and picking up cues from each other. Wilbur Schramm (1971) further elaborated on the idea of the processual nature of communication. He added another very significant element to the process of communication which is known as feedback.

So when A is in conversation with B, the following chain of events take place: A encodes a message and sends it through a channel. B receives the message, decodes it and responds by sending his feedback. This feedback can be in the form of a gesture or a word or even a long sentence. The sender will be able to understand the effectiveness of his message by the help of feedback which in turn would lead to better communication. The element of feedback makes Schramm's model reciprocal and extremely interactive in nature. According to Schramm, "it is misleading to think the communication process as starting somewhere and ending somewhere. It is really continuous."

Schramm also emphasised that the source begins with pictures in his head, but these cannot be transmitted unless they are encoded into signs for transmission.

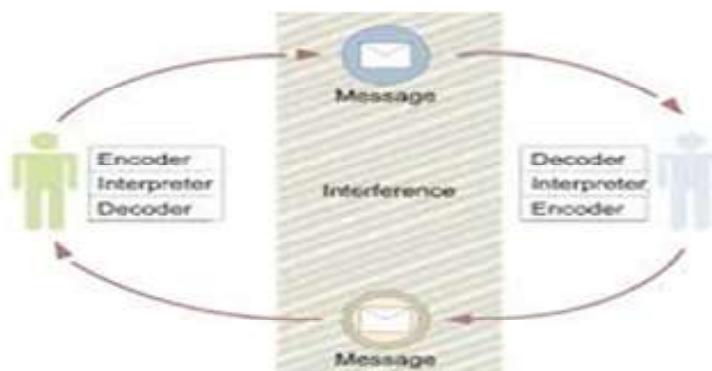


Fig 14.3

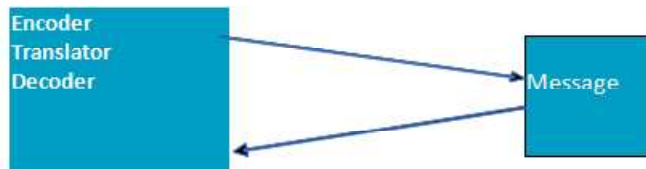


Fig. 14.4

So the first stage is the encoding of the message in words or other symbols. Once encoded the message is free of the sender. In other words, the sender has no control over the message. Even before we consider the effectiveness of the message, we need to consider whether the message will bring out the desired meaning? For this the message has to be decoded by the receiver.

According to Wilbur Schramm the important question is, ‘whether the picture in the head’ of the receiver will bear any remembrance to that in the head of the sender.’. In other words, the receiver and the sender have to be in tune with each other. This is similar to the need for a radio transmitter and receiver to be on the same frequency for the signal to get transmitted.

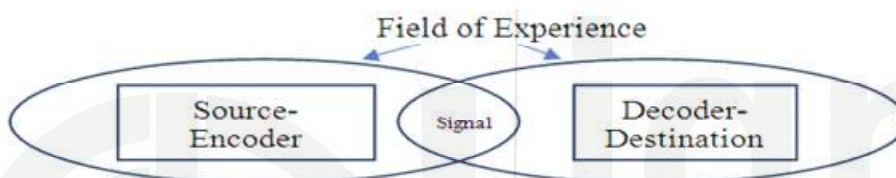


Fig. 14.5

In this model, Schramm introduces the concept of field of experience, which is vital for communication to take place. These fields are nothing but peripheries of the total human experience a person has. If both the source and receiver are in tune with each other, then the signal will be within the circles of accumulated experience of the two individuals. In such a case the communication process will be able to deliver the intended message.

Let us go back to the example of the usage of the word Lift instead of the word Elevator. The sender will encode the message according to her experience. So if the word Lift is used and the receiver is not familiar with it, in the context in which the sender is using it, there will be difficulty in communication. The problem here is that the Lift is not part of the receiver's field of experience. He/she is more used to the word Elevator. Thus it is important that while selecting words, signs or symbols to encode a message, the sender keeps in mind the experience of the receiver. This example can also be used to understand the concept of semantic noise.

What is a sign?

Messages are made of signs and symbols. A sign is a signal that stands for something in experience. A sign can be in the form of a word, image, a sound or gesture. Therefore the sign stands for something other than itself. For example, the word ‘chair’ has no natural relationship with the object it represents. This relationship has been created by convention in the English language. The word ‘chair’ can be interpreted at a denotative level as an object we sit on. While at the connotative level, it stands for power or hierarchy. The word could be meaningless in societies where people sit on the floor using woven mats. That is because it is not part of their field of experience.

14.5 BERLO'S MODEL OF COMMUNICATION



Fig. 14.6

This model as suggested by Berlo lists four basic elements involved in the process of communication. The source (S) is the originator of the message (M), which needs a channel (C) for it to reach the receiver (R). Here again we can observe that the entire process of communication is seen as a linear chain of events, geared towards transmitting a message to the receiver. The source, the originator of the entire process of communication drafts a message according to his skills and opinions, which is transmitted through a channel to reach out to the receiver.

Communication Skills

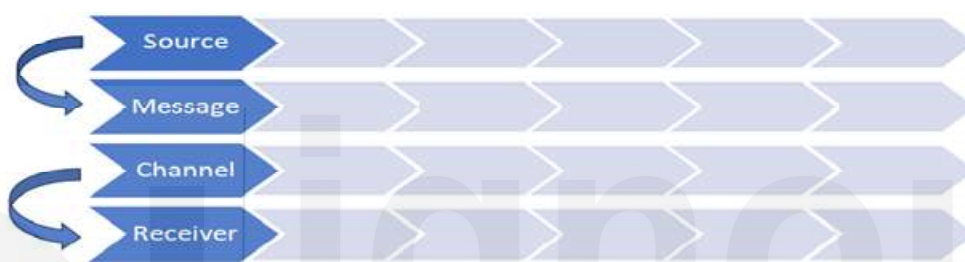


Fig. 14.7: A source encodes a message for a channel to a receiver who decodes the message: S-M-C-R Model

In Berlo's model, the source encodes the message according to his communication skills, knowledge, attitude and social and cultural values. The message itself has been understood with the help of various categories like its content, treatment and structure. The channel can be as diverse as hearing, touching, seeing, tasting and smelling. Finally the receiver decodes the message according to his/her knowledge, communications skills and attitudes.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What is semantic noise?

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2) What is the role of feedback in Osgood and Schramm's model of communication?

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14.6 GERBNER'S MODEL OF COMMUNICATION

George Gerbner's model brings another dimension into our understanding of communication. That is the dimension of perception and meaning. By doing so Gerbner makes a clear distinction between 'reality' and the message that shapes this 'reality'. According to Gerbner, the communication process has two dimensions –the perceptual and the communicating or means and control dimension.



The process in this model begins with an event E, something in external reality which is perceived as M (M can be a human or a machine such as the camera). M's perception of E results in E1. This is the perceptual dimension at the start of the process. The relationship between E and E1 involves selection. M cannot possibly perceive the whole complexity of E. If M is a machine this selection is determined by its engineering or its physical capabilities. But if M is human, however the selection is done through interaction and negotiation. In other words, an individual tries to match the external stimuli with internal patterns of thought to arrive at some perception of the event. This process involves the social and cultural experience of the individual. M brings into the process of perception his own experience and point of view. This also means that different people will have perceptions about the event E.

In the second stage in this model which is the vertical dimension, E1 turns into a signal or SE (signal about the event). This is in the form of a message or a statement about the Event or E. SE includes S, the form and shape of the message as well as E, or the content of the message. In this vertical dimension it is important to select the medium or channel of communication. This process of selection required M to have some control over the media or channels of communication. Just as E1 can never be a complete response to E similarly SE can never be a complete and comprehensive response to E1. There are bound to be some distortions or exclusions.

In the third stage we once again come back to the horizontal dimension. In this the receiver or M2 is making a perception of SE. Once again the receiver (M2) perceives SE through interaction and negotiation. M2 brings to SE his own needs as well as his social and cultural experience and finds meaning in the message accordingly to turn it into SE1.

What is important about Gerbner's model is that reality and our perception of reality are seen as distinct. That is why there is a difference between E the event and the percept E1. Similarly there is a difference between the message SE and how it is perceived by the receiver as SE1.

Activity 1

The Metro Rail is going to make its first ever trip in your neighbourhood, connecting it to the other parts of the mega city. How will you apply Gerbner's model to this event?

14.7 NEWCOMB'S MODEL

Newcomb's model is shaped like a triangle and its importance lies in the way it introduces us to the idea of the role that communication plays in a society. For Newcomb this role is to maintain equilibrium in society.

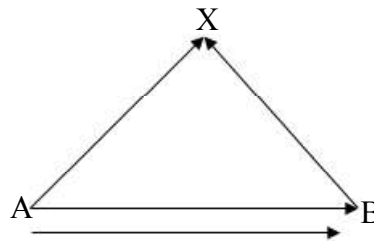


Fig. 14.8

In this model A and B are communicator and receiver. They may be individuals or organisations or a Government and its people. X is part of their social environment. ABX thus becomes a system, which means its internal relations are interdependent. In this ABX system if A changes, B and X will change as well; if A changes his relationship to X, B will have to change its relationship with X or A. The ABX system will be in an equilibrium only if A and B have similar attitude towards X. The more important a place X has in A and B's social environment the more urgent will be their need to communicate and share a common orientation towards X.

For example, if A is the Government, B is an organisation representing financial institutions and X is the economy then during the time of economic recession A and B will have to communicate more with each other because it concerns them both in a significant way. Similarly, during the period of war more communication and sharing of information are required between the A, the Government, and B the people over X which is the War.

What is important about Newcomb's model is its concern with those social situations which trigger the need for more communication. Secondly, Newcomb's model is concerned with broader orientations and attitudes between A and B towards X in the ABX system. Communication plays a key role in giving information about our social environment to create a state of equilibrium in a democratic society.

14.8 WESTLEY AND MACLEAN'S MODEL

This model designed by Westley and Maclean in 1957 is an important model for our understanding of mass media like newspapers, radio and television. This model is also understood as one that has extended Newcomb's model by introducing C as the new element in the ABX system. C acts as a filtering mechanism that decides what and how to communicate. Here is what the model looks like:

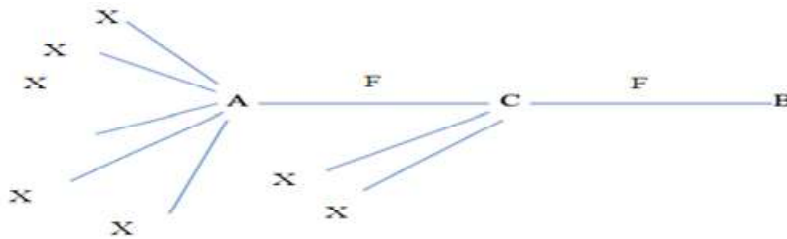


Fig. 14.9

X = Source of information

A = Sender

C = Gatekeeper

B = Audience

F = Feedback

In this model, A is the sender and B is the receiver or the audience. A relies on various sources (X) for information. Thus X or the social environment is closer to A than to B in this model. The arrows are now one way as in earlier linear models. What is significant about this model is the multifarious nature of X which is accessed by A. A the reporter writes her story by her interactions with X at various levels which are depicted as X1, X2, X3, X4 and so on. What is interesting here is that X can be interpreted in its plurality, representing several voices and events, thus providing several options of selection and negotiation to:

A. Thus mass media are extending the social environment (X) to be accessed by A, which B needs to relate to. But B has no direct contact with X. C acts as the Gatekeeper and decides which information that has been provided by A should ultimately reach the audience.

We can take the example of a newspaper reporter A, who sends a story to her editor C to get published in the newspaper. The editor may use the story but in a modified manner or take it as it is. It is also possible that the editor decides not to use the story at all. So the editor or C as shown in figure 10 is acting as a filter. After going through this filtering process, the message reaches B or the audience. B is very much at the mercy of both A and C. Even in terms of feedback, C acts as a filtering mechanism. The audience here is seen as dependent on mass media for information, while the means to satisfy this need for information is severely restricted through the process of selection as carried out by A and the process of gate-keeping carried out by C.

According to Dennis McQuail, Westley and Maclean's model is important since it makes an assertion that, "mass communicators do not originate messages or communication. Rather they relay to a potential audience their own account (news) of a selection of events occurring in the environment." This selection is done on the basis of an assessment of what the audience might find interesting.

Activity 2

A reporter working for a newspaper daily is sent to a temple town where several people have lost their lives in a stampede at the site of the temple. Apply the gatekeeping model and show how the news will reach the reader in this situation, keeping in mind all the actors involved as envisaged in this model.

Even though this model is useful for mass media like newspapers, it would work equally well for television, the internet or can be applied to film festivals, cultural festivals and diverse media forms like the animation industry. In the case of a film festival, a festival coordinator may receive several films to be considered for screening at a film festival. The curators of the festivals will have to then go through a process of selection and elimination to select a certain number of films that can be shown at the festival. They may set up the guidelines for the selection criteria according to the theme and the focus of the festival.

Westley and Maclean's model can thus be applied to various media technologies and networks. But the model is not concerned with the criteria for selection and elimination. It does not tell us on what grounds the process of gate-keeping takes place, but makes us aware of the role of gatekeepers in mass media.

14.9 JAKOBSON'S MODEL

This model draws from both linear and triangular models. Jakobson was a linguist and therefore frames his model on questions of meaning and the internal structure of a message. The importance of this lies in the fact that it moves far beyond the transmission perspective in communication. The model gives importance to the context and the codes involved in communication. The model enumerates six factors of communication with six corresponding functions.



Fig. 14.10

The (1) addressor sends a (2) message to the (3) addressee. To be effective, the message requires a (4) context which performs the referential function. The other factor is the (5) contact which keeps the physical and psychological connections between the addressor and the addressee open. The last element is the (6) code which is shared by the addressor and the addressee. Each of these elements performs an important corresponding function in verbal communication.

Factor	Type of Function	Function
Addressor	Emotive	Expresses feelings and attitudes of the addressor.
Context	Referential	Gives the factual information or the 'reality.' It is concerned with the descriptive or the denotative part of communication.
Message	Poetic	Gives importance to the style and aesthetics of communication
Contact	Phatic	It keeps the channels of communication open and points towards the relationships that are created through the interaction.
Code	Metalingual	It points towards the genre or the nature of interaction.
Addressee	Conative	It persuades or influences the addressee according to the desired goal

According to this model, each factor is important for communication to take place but it is not necessary that all the six functions should play an equally important role. A communication event may give importance to only one or more of these functions. For example, if the poetic function is given importance than other functions such as the referential function may become dormant. In other cases, the emotive function may take precedence over the other functions.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Explain how gatekeeping affects the process of communication.

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2) Identify the six functions of communication listed in Jakobson's model.

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14.10 A CRITIQUE OF TRANSMISSION PERSPECTIVE

We began this unit by studying Harold Lasswell's model which attempts to answer the question, who says what to whom, through what channel and with what effect? This model and most of the other models discussed above fall within the dominant paradigm, which is concerned with the technical efficiency of communication in transmitting or transporting information from the source to the destination. Thus the two ends of this process (the source and the destination) determine that linearity will be embedded in the way we approach communication. This is known as the transmission perspective of the communication models.

According to Dennis McQuail in the transmission driven models the message is determined by the source. One of problems with the transmission perspective is that it looks at communication in an instrumental way to bind it in a cause and effect format. Several of the models discussed come under the rubric of transmission perspective, which are geared towards a one-dimensional flow of the message from the sender to the receiver.

James Carey, a communication scholar introduced the Ritual or Expressive model of communication that depends on shared meanings and culture. The purpose of communication as conceptualised in the ritual perspective is not to bring out an

‘effect’ or to persuade someone, but rather to bring out the pleasures of a shared culture. Communication is not seen to perform a utilitarian function but is seen as a symbolic process whereby ‘reality is produced, maintained, repaired and transformed.’ The purpose of communication is not for the purpose of control but for the representation of shared beliefs. In the ritual model importance is given to the performative quality of communication rather than its efficiency. Therefore, meanings may be ambiguous and latent, drawing from a timeless shared culture which everyone is familiar with.

In this context it is interesting to see the way advertisements use the ritual model of communication ultimately to persuade the viewers to buy their products. For example, a familiar image in a commercial for cooking oil is a mother frying pooris for her children. This image draws upon the idea of purity and authenticity through the notion of ‘mother’s love’ thus reinforcing the idea of women as nurturers. So the commercial is not just about selling cooking oil but equally about creating symbolic associations which are familiar and part of a shared culture.

Transmission models usually suspect the audience to be passive, and the meanings exist only waiting to be decoded correctly. It severely underestimates the dynamic act of interpretation. It also shifts the power fulcrum in favour of the sender. Alternative models are described as constructivist models. They acknowledge that meanings can be generated and deconstructed by all parties involved, rather than just being reliant on senders and receivers. But scholars of this field reject the idea of producing scaled diagrams or structuring the process of communication. They instead opine that act of attaching meaning to a set of symbols is situated in the socio-cultural and political context.

14.11 LET US SUM UP

The purpose of this unit is to help us better understand the process of communication with the help of models which have been devised by several scholars. By using models as a tool we are able to map the communication process in a graphic form; this helps us understand better the flow of communication. Each model gives importance to different elements that are essential for communication. We notice that as we go along, the models become more and more complex leading us to ask different kinds of questions. This leads us towards more research and further need for models.

14.12 KEYWORDS

Mathematical model: Linear or telephone model of communication. Also known as the engineering model.

Encoder: Sender of message.

Decoder: Receiver of message

Semantics: Meanings attached to words.

Fields of experience: Periphery of total human experience.

Gatekeeping: Filtering mechanism of messages.

Ritual model: Focusses on shared meanings and culture.

Agenda setting: The theory that the media provide topics of discussion and importance for consumers.

Codebook: A menu or list of responses used in coding open-ended questions.

Construct: A combination of concepts that is created to describe a specific situation (for example, “authoritarianism”).

Degrees of freedom: An intentional and predetermined reduction in sample size to provide a conservative data adjustment to compensate for research error.

Homogeneity: Equality of control and experimental groups prior to an experiment; also called point of prior equivalency.

Longitudinal Study: The collection of data at different points in time.

Scientific Method: Asystematic, controlled, empirical, and critical investigation of hypothetical propositions about the presumed relationships among natural phenomena.

Open-ended Question: A question to which respondents are asked to generate an answer or answers with no prompting from the item itself (for example, “What is your favourite type of television program?”).

Proposition: A statement of the form “if A, then B” that links two or more concepts.

Sample: A subgroup or subset of a population or universe.

Secondary Analysis: The use of data collected by a previous researcher or another research organisation; also called data re-analysis.

14.13 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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14.14 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Semantic noise occurs when there is a difference of understanding the meaning of the communicated message between encoder and decoder (sender and receiver).

- 2) The sender will be able to understand the effectiveness of his message by the help of feedback which in turn would lead to better communication. The element of feedback makes Schramm's model reciprocal and extremely interactive in nature.

Check Your Progress – 2

- 1) Gatekeeping not only filters the initial message sent across, it also can add opinions and views of the person who is doing the gatekeeping to the message being sent forward.
- 2) The six functions are emotive, referential, poetic, phatic, metalingual and conative.



UNIT 15 THEORIES OF MASS COMMUNICATION

Structure

- 15.0 Introduction
- 15.1 Learning Outcomes
- 15.2 Why Study Theories?
- 15.3 Classification of Theories
- 15.4 Sociological Theories
 - 15.4.1 Cultivation Theory
 - 15.4.2 Agenda Setting Theory
 - 15.4.3 Uses and Gratification Theory
 - 15.4.4 Dependency Theory
- 15.5 Psychological Theories
 - 15.5.1 Attitudinal Change Theory
 - 15.5.2 Reinforcement Theory
 - 15.5.3 Persuasion and Attitude
 - 15.5.4 Social Learning Theory
- 15.6 Critical and Cultural Theories
 - 15.6.1 Marxist Theories
 - 15.6.2 Critical Theories
 - 15.6.3 Cultural Studies
 - 15.6.4 Political Economy Theory
- 15.7 Media - Society Theories
 - 15.7.1 Technology Determinism
 - 15.7.2 Media and the Public Sphere
 - 15.7.3 Audience Theories
 - 15.7.4 Feminist Media Theories
- 15.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 15.9 Keywords
- 15.10 References and Further Readings
- 15.11 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

15.0 INTRODUCTION

By studying the previous two units, you have been able to understand the communication process and its basic concepts along with models of communication. This unit will take you through an interesting journey of mass communication theories which will help you draw a relationship between media and society.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- describe different theories of mass communication;
- discuss their implications in different social contexts;
- analyse on the basis of these theories the media society equation; and
- apply these theories to understand media messages in personal and cultural context.

15.2 WHY STUDY THEORIES

You usually begin the day in the morning with a cup of “the best and most refreshing green tea in the world” or a glass of milk which is the “only pure brand that makes your bones strong”. The morning newspaper has so many colourful segments shouting for attention and as it is time for breakfast, the “best bread in town” makes your morning complete, rearing you to go. Then as you travel to your college or work place, the larger than life hoardings look at you trying to impress why the product/service they are highlighting should be your preferred choice over others. The FM radio plugged in your ears tells you about the grand sale on garments, holidays, restaurants and shopping for festivals. In between it also informs you on news, both national and local mostly sensational or commercial. Then as you approach the workplace or college, you try to put things in order by recapitulating the tasks set for the day. These are only the first few morning hours and you are already bombarded with seamless media messages the subtle effects of which are not simple for the human mind to gauge.

So how do you know what to do? Whether to believe such media messages or refrain from it? And if you decide to believe, how much should you believe? The choice again is to be or not to be. Media messages play games with the human mind, challenge our intellect, try to influence our behaviour in favour of or against something or someone and even tell us what choices to make. And they do all this within the realm of our personal, cultural and social systems.

15.3 CLASSIFICATION OF THEORIES

Mass communication theories are classified in various ways. This is because theories or the way social processes are explained keep changing or advancing depending on technological, political and social factors. Most mass media theorists classify theories based on eras of development of mass media. And rightly so, because the way the media operated in society and the importance they held from time to time changed with the change in technology. So while theories are generally classified as those of the era of mass society, the era of scientific perspective, the era of limited effects and the era of cultural theory, to facilitate greater understanding, we classify them as sociological, psychological, critical and cultural theories and media society theories.

15.4 SOCIOLOGICAL THEORIES

Sociological theories explain the role of media with regard to social relationships and in economic and political contexts.

15.4.1 Cultivation Theory

George Gerbner’s cultivation theory tries to draw an equation between symbolic structures, audience views and behaviour. The theory was advocated when

television was new and much research was being done on it. Cultivation analysis explains that television constructs a new reality for the audiences which may have no bearing on the real world. TV propagates a new reality which is its own creation and is well accepted socially and culturally by the audiences, especially heavy viewers. The theory was based on five assumptions:

- 1) TV requires no additional resources like reading skills, money or mobility. So TV content can be consumed by people of all age groups at any time of their choice.
- 2) TV at that time was the first medium to have shared public messages audio-visually leading to the creation of a pseudo culture and mainstreaming a TV created understanding of society.
- 3) Such pseudo reality does not create attitudinal change, rather creates basic frames of reference which help audiences make decisions and judgements in life generally.
- 4) The TV created reality through its content aimed at stabilising the socio-cultural patterns. This is to maintain the power relationships in a society. So TV content is not directed to creating any revolution or major change in the existing socio-cultural set up, it only reinforces the already existing power relationships.
- 5) The observable and measurable changes propelled by this TV-created perception of reality are relatively small due to a number of intervening variables. At times, the social reality constructed as a result of TV viewing may bring about alternate changes like a person may start spending less time on TV.

The active audience theory challenges the long term cumulative effects of cultivation theory. In the contemporary world where the audiences use multiple media to satisfy their information, entertainment and various other needs, one cannot assume that exposure to any one medium can have a major effect on the audiences' perception of reality. Nevertheless, the subtle effects of the theory cannot be negated.

15.4.2 Agenda Setting Theory

The idea of agenda setting was first discussed in terms of election campaigns in 1972 by Max Mc Combs and Donald Shaw. According to this theory, the news media tell the public what the important issues of the day are. For example, the news that appears first and in prime time is perceived to be more important by the audience. The media do not tell the audience what to think but they do tell what to think about. So while the media may make a diplomatic meeting between several countries look important, they cannot have a say on whether the audience thinks it will do any good to the country's economy. The effects of agenda setting have also been established by research. The agenda setting effects are the maximum in first stories as they have the maximum audience attention and are uninterrupted and without distractions. So the placement of stories is important. Also, there is consistency in importance given to issues across different media. But powerful videos and images can reduce such effects on the audiences' mind as they can emotionally or otherwise divert and absorb attention to the issue of presentation.

The importance given to an issue by the media may not be close to the real world issues. So what is important in the media is not what is really important but what is made important by forces and people in power. This shapes the social and political realities for common people. Also related to agenda setting is the Priming effect of media which is generally used for news management. This is used more in terms of diverting attention from important issues in the public sphere like a big military adventure or foreign affairs' initiative.

15.4.3 Uses and Gratification Theory

This is a limited effects theory which suggests that media are not supreme and audiences are not passive. The effects of media are limited to what the audiences allow them to be. So it is not what the media do to the audiences but what audiences do with the media and why do they use media. There are various needs that audiences look at satisfying like information, entertainment, companionship and escape. While people are becoming more techno-friendly and real time socialisation has taken a back seat, the importance of media has increased in people's lives. One may wish to know the diplomatic efforts that a country is making with the neighbouring country to bring back a fighter pilot who by mistake landed in the enemy territory – the need to be informed and updated. One may want to watch the latest film that one's peer group has been talking about – the need to be entertained and the need for social identity. After a stressful day at work, one may want to forget about it and watch a web series after dinner – the need for escape.

The above examples indicate that the needs of the audience have a bearing on the socio – cultural context. The expectation from the media is based on this context and type of media used. The content explains media influences, media choices and media behaviors while the type of media used will differ in content and presentation.

15.4.4 Dependency Theory

Propounded by Melvin De Fleur and Sandra Ball-Rokeach in 1975, this theory has left behind the limited effects theory. According to this theory the power of a mass medium is decided by how much the audiences are dependent on that medium. There were several assertions that the theory was made of:

- 1) The power or influence of mass media is composed of the relationship of the social system of which the media are a part, the media's role in that system and the audience relationship to that media.
- 2) Whether the media is able to exercise influence to alter the beliefs and behaviour of the audiences is decided by the degree of dependence of audiences on that media.
- 3) In modern society, the dependence on media is at multiple levels like, to understand the outside world, to find meaning and take meaningful actions in a given social set up and to find fantasy and escape.
- 4) The degree of dependence on mass media increases with (i) greater number of functions that we put a media system to serve (ii) when there is greater change and conflict in a society as the audience depends more on media to make opinions or take decisions.

Let us understand this with an example. Whenever we hear of a major train accident or a cyclone or a terrorist attack or to look up at election results, we immediately use media to access the latest information, to analyse the available information to make an opinion and to act on it. Our decisions and actions depend on media use and this dependency increases with the increase in use of media.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What are the effects of agenda setting in the media?

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2) What factors contribute to the degree of dependence on media?

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15.5 PSYCHOLOGICAL THEORIES

The work done on psychological aspects of communication was probably the most important in the times of post-World War I. The bearings of the human mind and the way media affect it, how communication influences the decisions and actions that an individual makes and various nuances related to them were studied under this. Some of the psychological theories covered under it include attitudinal change theories, individual difference theory, persuasion and attitude and social learning theory.

15.5.1 Attitudinal Change Theory

Before you understand the processes of selectivity, it is important to understand the related concept of dissonance. The dissonance theory argued that when an individual confronts new information, one faces a mental discomfort. This could be due to change in the comfort zone of an individual which may involve action, decision making or may be purely situational.

Carl Hovland and his team of researchers tested the effectiveness of this theory in 1949. The theory of attitudinal change suggested that in order to overcome dissonance, the human mind on a conscious or subconscious level makes use of three selective processes. These selective processes which are a result of personal choices of the audiences are explained below:

- 1) **Selective exposure:** This process explains that when an individual is confronted with a situation leading to dissonance, in order to reduce it, one exposes oneself or gives attention to only that information which is consistent with one's attitudes and beliefs. One's pre-existing experiences, perception of reality, preferences, interests, values and beliefs lead to formation of one's attitude. These are the decisive factors for selection of information one chooses to expose himself to.

For example, if you are asked to attend a session in a seminar or a talk or lecture, you choose the subject depending on your area of interest. So you are selective about what you expose yourself to.

- 2) **Selective perception:** After one has chosen what to expose one's mind to, all of the exposed information is not perceived meaningfully. The interpretation of messages will take place selectively on the basis of message consistency with one's pre-existing attitudes and beliefs.

For example, in the talk or lecture that you attended, a number of points were made. But you did not think of each of them. You gave a further thought to a few select ideas. This is called selective perception.

- 3) **Selective retention:** Of all that is perceived, the human mind is selective about what it retains for long and the messages retained depend on how consistent they are with one's pre-existing attitudes and beliefs.

For example, a few days after the talk or lecture, only a few ideas remain with you. The rest of the content you do not remember. This is called selective retention.

15.5.2 Reinforcement Theory

Joseph Klapper in his book 'The Effects of Mass Communication' (1960) explained the reinforcement theory with selective processes as the basis, focusing on limited effects of media. TV had not yet become a mass medium then. According to this theory, mass media are not capable of bringing any change by them, it depends on what Klapper called a nexus of mediating factors and influences like social and religious factors which primarily affect the audiences and media play a supportive role. Whenever media have had direct effects, it has been either because the mediating factors have not been operational or when the mediating factors themselves have been impelling towards change. This theory stressed that there are minimal situations where media can have direct effects on the audience and whether media act as a contributory agent of bringing about change or are directly responsible for it would depend on communication situation or on different aspects of media and communication.

For example, when as a result of a certain political ideology, there are communal riots at a place, the media are expected to report with ethical restraint and without creating sensationalism, but the media cannot be expected to calm the situation or take any fruitful action in such a situation. Another example can be when a certain economic decision is taken the politics of the country tries to gain mileage by playing on economic sentiments while gaining political mileage out of it. But the media alone cannot change the way audiences respond to it or force a rational mindset. It only reports the predominant perceptions of the influential class of society, polity and religion which affect the audiences to varying degrees.

15.5.3 Persuasion and Attitude

You must be aware by now that mass media serves three primary purposes - information, education and entertainment. There is a fourth purpose of the communication through mass media, which is persuasion. Persuasion is the process of influencing the perspective and thus outlook and finally the decision of the audiences. While it uses information, its purpose moves beyond just informing. It attempts at an active decision making and implementation. Five primary factors that play a key role in designing a message for the purpose of persuasion are:

- 1) **Belief:** It is a set of ideas pertaining to what one may think to be true or false. Beliefs are easier to change than attitudes. When one is confronted with situations that are juxtaposed to the reality one believes in, then one is more likely to amend one's belief. While some people believe that one political party has the benefit of a minority at heart, other groups may believe the opposite, and there will be few more that will realise the agenda behind it.
- 2) **Value:** Value is the merit, worth or usefulness of something which is held personally by someone. It is what a person deems important. For someone, saving money on education might be important, while others feel that one should spend maximum on it.
- 3) **Motive:** It refers to the aims or self-interests of a person in a situation. For example, while buying a gift, the customer's decision may change based on who one is gifting it to.
- 4) **Attitude:** Attitude is the mindset which is most difficult to change as it is formed as a result of constant reinforcement of a certain kind of behavior. For example, some may have a positive attitude towards a political party or technology or ever changing fashion trends, while some may feel negatively about one or more of these. At all times, an attitude is backed by a strong reason for holding it.
- 5) **Behaviour:** It is the action taken by people. It can be observed and is affected by all the above factors. While it is affected by the media, it could be out of sync as well, due to other factors like peer pressure, climate and budget among others. Advertising works on this theory. While the beliefs, values and motives are difficult to change, advertising aims to introduce conditions and later establish beliefs and values as the new norm.

For example, 'Daag acche hain', is a very literal example where the perception of soiled clothes is being changed. The advertisers are encouraging mothers to encourage their kids to play, thus redefining the process of cleaning. The phrase becomes catchy and is aimed at changing the behavior of the audience resulting in increasing the sales of the product.

15.5.4 Theory of Social Learning

Albert Bandura in 1986 gave the social learning theory also called the observational learning theory. According to this theory, much learning takes place in terms of an individual's social behavior and development from what one

observes and experiences in the environment. Much of this learnt behavior was earlier picked from television alone. Bandura gave a sequence for such learning to take place: attention, retention, production and motivation.

One pays attention to media messages that are of interest to an individual. One tries to retain it by modeling or copying it which may be through (i) imitation or (ii) identification. Imitated behavior is when a behavior observed in the environment (including media) is copied exactly in personal life. For example, one tries to imitate the styles and way of speaking of one's favourite actor. Or when crime occurs based on the storyline of a tele-serial or movie is also an example of imitated behavior. Identified behavior is more symbolic or generalised and though not exactly copied, yet presents a response that is related to what is observed in media. For example, men sporting a particular hairstyle or stubble and traditional moustaches are an identified behavior.

The social learning theory later led to the emergence of social cognition theory.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What are the three factors in attitudinal change theory?

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2) What are the five elements of persuasion?

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15.6 CRITICAL AND CULTURAL THEORIES

Critical and cultural theories look at the process of culture production 'critically'. These theories analyse the social structures and practices that shape them. Culture in terms of media terminology refers to various products of media, which could include a photograph, language, a film or an article.

15.6.1 Marxist Theories

Marxism is a broad ideology which in essence is economic. Some of you with a commerce or arts background might be aware of it. In a nutshell it states that those who hold the means of production produce according to their needs and

are known as *bourgeoisie*. The proletariat consists of the workers who toil to create the products and are still deprived of using them to their full potential. Translating to the media scenario, the media messages are seen as the products and media channels as means of production. The elite who own the media channels are the current day bourgeoisie and the audiences are the proletariat. Media and their messages constitute a part of the common culture, and their production is the process of culture production.

The theory works in two stages: first is media ownership. People who own the media channels will use media to serve their vested interests, consciously or subconsciously. The popular is not always what the masses want, but rather what the media elites think the masses want. You may have heard that in the context of the current television news scenario in India, it is often debated and discussed that a channel is owned by a big business group or a minister or a political party and as a result it gives a particular angle to the news stories to popularise their ideology. Second is the audience interpretation. It is further dependent on modes of access and reach for the audience segment. Studying this helps in understanding who comprehends what and why.

Another view came from Stuart Hall, famous for his theory of encoding and decoding. He argued that the media channels appear to reflect reality while they are actually constructing it. Besides the mass media not only function in the interests of the owners of production means, but they are also 'a field of ideological struggle'. Hall further explained the readings in three types:

- Dominant reading: by the ones whose social context favours the preferred reading
- Negotiated reading: by the ones who modulate the reading according to their social set up
- Oppositional reading: by the ones whose social positions are in opposition with the reading

15.6.2 Critical Theories

The Marxist theories gave rise to what was later accepted to be the Frankfurt school of 'Critical Theory'. Most important philosophers associated with the Frankfurt school were Theodor Adorno, Herbert Marcuse and Max Horkheimer. Later philosophers like Antonio Gramsci and Jurgen Habermas were also associated with the critical theories.

Critical theories aim to critique and change the society rather than just understand or explore it, as is the case with the traditional theories. For this, critical theories are applied to many subjects of social sciences and humanities. Post 1960s, after the establishment of communication studies as a separate discipline, language, text and symbolism have been perceived as the foundation stone for studying humanities. So much so that Habermas described the critical social theories as a study of the field of communication.

The theories aim at analysing texts from the perspective of what is intended and by whom, what are the implications of representations or rather misrepresentations and how they in turn justify the ideology propagated through the texts. To put it simply:

- The text is studied of intended meaning
- The meaning is further explored for representation of a contextual reality
- The contextual reality is then put vis-a-vis against the ideology the text generators aim to propagate.

The critical theories surmise that mass media define the way we perceive the world and are a 'culture industry'. Antonio Gramsci used the term hegemony to describe the dominance of one social class over another which manifested through the media messages. This shaped the world view of the less dominant class and normalised what the media messages contained.

15.6.3 Cultural Studies

Media production is also the process of culture production. From the Complan Boy to Cibaca Geetmala to Gajini haircuts to Instagram icons, each of these is a byproduct of the media messages and is a part of the process of culture production for the masses.

Richard Hoggart used the term 'Cultural Studies' for the first time in 1964 in the UK. As the name implies, cultural studies are the branch dealing with the study of the media texts in the light of the cultural context it is arising from. The scholars of cultural studies strive to understand the culture and its forms, origins and context. Embracing various methodological approaches and philosophies, cultural studies use hermeneutics, postmodernism, sociology, economics and even anthropology to study culture and its production. Culture under this branch of study is not understood as a fixed entity but as a dynamic one.

Cultural study researchers also probe the association of power with the emerging social phenomena such as gender, class, ethnicity, race and national identity. Thus, many approaches including the feminist theories, critical race theory, structuralism and literary theories lie under its gamut. The aim of cultural studies is to understand culture and its making and acceptance through the lens of power. The objective becomes not only to analyse the culture, the process of its formulation, but how it is positioned in the society as well. It strives to continuously evaluate the social practices and direct towards a political action.

Culture studies also view consumption of culture as an active process. Scholars have opined that consumers also challenge the meanings of media texts. The major contribution to this area comes from Stuart Hall and John Fiske. Meaning of text is also extremely flexible and dynamic. From TV programmes to film scores to hairstyles to webpage layouts, according to Roland Barthes, an acclaimed French semiotician, every text can be dissected and read.

15.6.4 Political Economy Theory

The political economy theory is said to be suggested by Harold Innis in his book 'Empire and Communications'. The book is further said to have inspired Marshall McLuhan to formulate his theories. The theory is a popular branch in communication studies which discusses the power relations that make the process of communication through mass media possible. Further, the political economy theory also studies the social relationships within the mass media systems, the producers, the distributors and the consumers. It also focuses on the role of the state and the involvement of technological developments.

The focus areas of the theory are:

- 1) **Media ownership:** In today's concentrated media ownership, lack of diversity in contents has become an issue of concern. Large media conglomerates tilt the quality of content and thus raise the issues of inclusion in media participation.
- 2) **Peripheral processes:** From advertising to social media services to events, these processes also affect the content to some extent. When producers are the advertisers as well, their influence on content becomes obvious.
- 3) **Government policies:** Lastly, the state policies on production, distribution and consumption of content also affect the operation of the industry at large.

This theory finds greater applicability in few segments of media when compared with others. For instance, in journalism, a concentrated ownership would induce bias in reporting. A lot of advertorials and PR material makes up for what is supposed to be news. With an understanding of the economics behind the media ownership patterns, one can trace this bias and make a negotiated reading of the text.

15.7 MEDIA – SOCIETY THEORIES

15.7.1 Technological Determinism

The theory undermines the growth of culture or ownership patterns on content creation, but focuses on the availability and use of technology in a given society. This practically means that with mass production comes mass access and consumption. Without the invention of the printing press, there would be no mass consumption of books and neither would the literacy level of the society increase.

The theory can be further divided:

- **Hard determinism:** This branch believes that technology is independent from social concerns. Humans align themselves in accordance with technology and we do not hold much choice in the manner how and why. A social system whose structure allows a technology to grow will imbibe its features and thus become more advanced than a structure which does not.
- **Soft determinism:** This branch believes in greater flexibility. It opines that technology could be the guiding force in human evolution, but it is not the only factor. Also, cultures and traditions will vary how the technology is adapted and applied in a society.

15.7.2 Media and Public Sphere

The concept of public sphere was formulated sometime in the eighteenth century. It is basically a space where people come together to discuss social problems without any hierarchy. The discussion leads to suggesting a political action. The discussion comprises all perspectives from various sections of society. Jürgen Habermas theorised this space in 1991 as a space where public meets private.

He pointed out few features of this space:

- 1) Open to all citizens
- 2) All citizens act on their own behalf and do not represent political or business interests.
- 3) No hierarchy in the citizens
- 4) Discussion on social issues
- 5) Formation of public opinion
- 6) Citizen involvement in policy making at governmental level

Habermas considers state power as public power as it is established through the agency of elections. He presses on the need of public spheres to mediate between the state and the society as it gives a platform for discussion and opinion formation for the public. Many physical spaces in the past have served as the public spheres, for instance, Britain's coffee houses, and France's salons.

With the rise of new media, various opinions from scholars across the world have emerged considering the web as a public sphere. The Internet allows anyone and everyone to voice their opinion on social media platforms. As of now, when there are online influencers to shape the consumer opinion for various brands, the discussions happening online are certainly helping a lot of citizens in the opinion formation. Today the web is also emerging as the primary information gathering medium and at times these opinions and discussion boards also spread misinformation among the masses.

15.7.3 Audience Theories

In the process of creating and disseminating media messages, discussing the role of the audience is imperative. Who is the audience, how are they engaging with the media messages, what messages are being preferred over others? The term, 'audience theory,' refers to any theory which explores the relationship between the audience and the media text. It includes:

- a) **Hypodermic needle model:** Where the text is received without negotiation and accepted by the receiver. Just like a needle penetrates the skin and no resistance can be offered, so do media messages affect the audience. This was the first theory that tried to explain the effect of media messages on the audience.
- b) **Two step flow:** This theory talks about the opinion leaders, who usually are people with high media literacy, who filter and diffuse the media content to the masses. In this case, the power does not solely lie with the media, but also with the opinion leaders in the society up to some extent.
- c) **Reception theory:** This theory emphasizes the process of understanding of texts. Underlining the heterogeneous cultural background of the people constituting the audience, this theory propounds that the meaning derived of a text will differ for all individuals.
- d) **Active audience theory:** A study by Zimmerman and Bauer revealed that an audience also plays an active role in the production of media messages. In times of social media and user generated content on sites like YouTube, this theory does not need any further examples.

15.7.4 Feminist Media Theories

Feminist theories are an umbrella term for a group of theories that explore the definition and representation of gender or concepts related to gender. The theorists of this branch argue that almost all aspects of life can be deciphered in relation to gender. They also opine that gender defines the division of power and responsibilities in the society. The feminist theorists not only work to document the inequality, but also to suggest and shift the balance to equilibrium.

Feminism has not remained as a mere bunch of theories but has manifested itself as a social movement in recent times. While largely unorganised, three different versions have emerged prominently:

- 1) Liberal feminism: It has been the foundation of the movement, propagating that women have been deprived of equal rights and have been oppressed as a group in the public sphere.
- 2) Radical feminism: It believes that giving equal social rights won't help until we change our social structures. Rights are mere extensions to regularise what the society believes to be just. Without changing the social fabric, many women will not even be able to avail the rights.
- 3) Marxist feminism: The theorists belonging to this branch believe that the means of production have always lied with men, thus depriving women, social equity.

Feminist theorists largely study the following:

- 1) Representation of gender in media texts: While portrayal of women has been a subject of constant debate, at times men also suffer from the rigid rules of patriarchy. This stems from the discussion that gender is not merely polar, but fluid. One could be a male, and yet not confirm to the societal regulations for the male gender completely.
- 2) Production of media texts: How many filmmakers are female? How do their stories differ from the stories told by the male film makers? When the means of production lie in the hands of the other, how does the product change?
- 3) Reading of the text: What are the different ways of consumption of media texts based on the consumer's gender? Why does a man like watching action movies more than a woman?

15.8 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we learnt about what is implied by different theories of mass communication, their classification in terms of sociological, psychological, critical and cultural and media-society theories and how each of them explains different aspects of media effects in the socio cultural context. The sociological theories section discussed the varying degrees of effects media has on the audience and the relationship that an individual builds with the media. The psychological theories section discussed how people engage with media on a mental level, sometimes consciously and sometimes sub-consciously. The critical and cultural theories section discussed the intervention of Marxism in media theories and how culture is influenced by it. The last section of the unit explored the media society equation with technological intervention and expanding of the public sphere.

15.9 KEYWORDS

Public sphere : A place where people can participate in any discussion without being restricted by social class

Persuasion : Communication aimed to change behavior

Bourgeoisie : People of social class who hold the means of production

Proletariat : Workers who toil to create the products

15.10 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

- Baran, S. J., McDonald, E., and Engberg, J. (2004). Introduction to Mass Communication: Media Literacy and Culture. New York, McGraw-Hill.
- Mc Quail, Denis. (1987). Mass Communication Theory: An Introduction. Delhi, Sage Publications Inc

15.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The agenda setting effects are the maximum in first stories as they have the maximum audience attention and are uninterrupted and without distractions. So the placement of stories is important. Also, there is consistency in importance given to issues across different media. But powerful videos and images can reduce such effects on the audiences' mind as they can emotionally or otherwise divert and absorb attention to the issue of presentation.
- 2) The degree of dependence on mass media increases with (i) greater number of functions that we make a media system to serve (ii) when there is greater change and conflict in a society as the audience depends more on media to make opinions or take decisions.

Check Your Progress – 2

- 1) Selective exposure, selective perception and selective retention
- 2) Five elements of persuasion are:
 - a) Belief
 - b) Value
 - c) Motive
 - d) Attitude
 - e) Behaviour

UNIT 16 DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION CONCEPTS AND THEORIES

Structure

- 16.0 Introduction
- 16.1 Learning Outcomes
- 16.2 Dominant Paradigm of Development
 - 16.2.1 Approaches to Dominant Paradigm of Development
 - 16.2.2 Critique of Dominant Paradigm of Development
- 16.3 Theories Since Dominant Paradigm of Development
 - 16.3.1 Structuralist Theory
 - 16.3.2 Dependency Theory
- 16.4 Alternative Approaches to Development
 - 16.4.1 Basic Needs Approach
 - 16.4.2 Another Development Paradigm
 - 16.4.3 Participatory Approach
 - 16.4.4 'Capability' as Development
 - 16.4.5 Rights Based Approach
- 16.5 Approaches to Development Communication
- 16.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 16.7 Keywords
- 16.8 References and Further Readings
- 16.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

16.0 INTRODUCTION

Development and well-being of any society is measured in terms of their access to better education, health care, equality and freedom in the modern world. Improving the quality of life of citizens and reduction in poverty are two essential components of development. Although economic factors have a substantial role in development, it is now increasingly recognised that money alone cannot qualify as an end to the concept of wellbeing. In recent years, globalisation, which was considered to promote global economic growth and social progress, has in-fact led to growing income inequality and greater social inequities. It has been asserted that inclusive development is the need of the hour to effectively tackle disparities that are inherent in the development initiatives mooted in a globalised economic system. Thus the concept of development has undergone several transformations in the post-Second World War period.

The role of media in development also had to be redefined to address the emergent challenges and aspirations. Mass media had to confront internal (ownership, reach, revenue and technology) as well as external (cultural imbalance, political influence, market forces and competition) issues in the process of positioning itself in the realm of development discourse in a globalised environment.

Development Communication (Devcom) has addressed some of these issues and Devcom theorists have mooted many communication strategies for development – appropriate for respective regions of the world.

In this unit, we shall take an overview of the concept of development and discuss various theories of development including the dominant paradigm of development; structuralist and dependency theories, and alternative approaches to development. We shall also look at the recent debates in communication for development.

16.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you should be able to:

- define the concept of development;
- discuss various approaches to development;
- explain the theories of development communication; and
- provide a critique of these concepts and theories

16.2 DOMINANT PARADIGM OF DEVELOPMENT

We have earlier discussed that the post-colonial era paved the way for new ideas for development in developing countries. Most of the early theories were founded on western models of development which heavily relied on industrialisation and technological adaptation. Prominent among them was the Modernisation theory or Dominant Paradigm of Development which aimed at replicating the western model of development through industrialisation, free market and urbanisation and ‘take’ development to the ‘under-developed’ regions of the world mainly through aid agencies, NGOs, UN bodies and multilateral organisations. Having roots in the Atlantic Charter of 1941 and the Marshall Plan of 1948, the proposed initiatives were portrayed as an attempt to improve the conditions of the under developed world by helping them with scientific advances and industrial progress by US governments. However, later on, Marshall Plan was criticised as an effort to establish political hegemony of the US to counter the communist aggression from the USSR.

The key features of Modernisation Approach were:

- Industry is the prime mover of the economy. Therefore a major part of investment must go to industry and what is required are raw material, transportation and training.
- Modern society requires more specialists rather than generalists in each field (health and industry).
- Public education, health care and family planning require intensive intervention for participatory governance and well-being of the people.
- The profit from industries should trickle down to other sectors such as agriculture and rural technology.
- To ensure rapid development, necessary information can be diffused and persuasion can occur through the mass media.

Modernisation approach firmly believed that urbanisation and industrialization were the most feasible routes to achieve modernity. Having an economic-oriented

view, it sees development as an unilinear, evolutionary process and defines the state of underdevelopment in terms of observable quantitative differences between so-called poor and rich countries on the one hand, and traditional and modern societies on the other hand (Servaes & Paitachalee, 2002). This approach was also known as the Dominant Paradigm of Development.

16.2.1 Approaches to Dominant Paradigm of Development

Dominant Paradigm called for mechanical emulation of western ideas of development and underscored the ethnic culture and history of a country. It considered Mass Media a strong agent in development and the paradigm found powerful effects of media in bringing about socio-economic change.

Daniel Lerner

One of the prominent figures of the modernisation paradigm was Daniel Lerner who wrote the book, 'The Passing of the Traditional Society and Modernising the Middle East' (1958). He postulated that urbanisation, literacy, mass media exposure and political participation could be the change agents for transition from traditional agrarian communities to modern industrial societies. According to Lerner, development failed because people in third world countries were unable to 'empathise' or imaginatively identify with the modern societies new roles, and a changed and 'better' way of life and hence they remained fatalistic, unambitious and resistant to change. He saw the media as filling this need of promoting interest among the people for embracing change.

High media consumption was seen as a prerequisite for people's participation to change their own traditional customs and beliefs and key to bringing about political and economic participation and overall social development. Media was considered a 'multiplier' and enhancer and its expected role was to make ideas of modernisation attractive, change people's psychological state, and teach them skills which are required for a modern society (Narula, 2014). Lerner believed in the media's ability to transform its audience into an empathetic state where they will embrace the ideas of modernity. People here were passive recipients of ideas advocated by the authoritarian administration. Consequent to the achievements of urbanisation and literacy, people may use mass media as mobility multipliers to create a climate of acceptance of change.

Wilbur Schramm

Wilbur Schramm extended the opinions of Lerner in his work, 'Mass Media and National Development (1979)' in favour of 'modernisation' through mass media-which he termed as magic multipliers. He perceived mass media as agents of social change as media has the magical capability to inform, educate and persuade people and accomplish the transitions to new customs and practices of a community. Schramm further argued that a nation that wants to accelerate the process of development must allow information to flow as quickly and as widely as possible so as to make relevant information available to them, as well as understand their needs and of the opportunities for meeting them. This will facilitate the decision making process and will help the people put the new practices smoothly and swiftly into effect. Schramm forcefully postulated that the mass media has the potential to widen horizons, to focus attention, to raise aspirations and to create a climate for development.

Walt Whitman Rostow

Walt Whitman Rostow's linear stages of growth model (1960) laid out the path for building a 'modern industrial' society in five transitional stages. They are traditional societies, pre-conditions for take-off (existed in traditional economy), take-off, drive to maturity and the age of high mass consumption. Traditional society was constrained by 'rigid social structure and irrational psychological attitudes. According to Rostow's model, a country needed to follow some rules of development to reach the take-off stage. They are-

- Investment rate of a country needs to be increased to at least 10% of its GDP
- One or two manufacturing sectors with a high rate of growth need to be established
- An institutional, political and social framework has to exist or be created in order to promote the expansion of those sectors.

The Rostow concept had some serious flaws. It assumed that development can be achieved through a basic sequence of stages which are the same for all countries. It measured development solely by means of the increase of GDP per capita. The model focused on characteristics of development, but did not identify the causal factors which lead development to occur. As such, it neglected the social structures that have to be present to foster development.

Everett M Rogers

Rogers' (1962) Diffusion of Innovations theory was also in line with the economic and technological aspects of the modernisation paradigm. It considered Modernisation as a process of diffusion whereby individuals are 'persuaded' to move from a traditional way of life to a different, more technically developed one (Servaes, 2002; 2007). The approach focuses upon the process of diffusion and adoption of innovations in a systematic and planned way.

Emphasising the importance of mass communication in the diffusion process, according to Rogers, its influence operates by a 'two step flow' process of awareness through the mass media and development of favourable attitudes and adaptation by inter-personal channels, particularly, "opinion leaders". Hence when a message is propagated, such as a new family planning method, or a new fertiliser, a segment of the population adopts it, and develops a positive attitude towards it. These people then directly or indirectly shape the positive attitude of others who remain indifferent to the message as people like to get confirmation from people they know and trust.

Originally having five stages – awareness, interest, evaluation, trial and adoption, the model is considered to be hierarchic and unidirectional as communications are directed from the informed 'source' to the uninformed 'receiver'. Rogers, however, later revisited and included the element of 'participation' in communication. The explanation for the term 'development' given by Rogers subsequently enjoyed acceptance from scholars across social science disciplines since it included the concepts of equality, freedom and individual expressions. It said, "Development is a widely participatory process of directed social change in a society, intended to bring about both social and material advancement including greater equality, freedom and other valued qualities for the majority of the people through their gaining greater control over their environment" (Rogers, 1976).

16.2.2 Critique of Dominant Paradigm of Development

The dominant paradigm faced severe criticism for its over emphasis on technological and economic aspects of development, under-estimation of traditional wisdom of communities in the developing countries, deliberate silence on issues of human rights, environment, personal freedom, and democratic participation etc. Communication in the dominant paradigm was essentially a linear, mass media model aimed at transmitting information and messages from one point to many others, in a vertical, top-down manner. Strong belief in the persuasive power of media, and the use of media to persuade people to adopt ideas about development dominated the structuring of communications for development. The pro-persuasion and pro-top down bias of the modernisation paradigm questioned the intelligence of local communities to make choices and their indigenous knowledge. According to several scholars the paradigm intentions were only establishing western hegemony by diffusing inventions, ideas and values conceived in the west and undermining the 'internal forces' in the developing countries (Mody, 1991).

The dominant paradigm of development was criticised by various scholars as it also failed to bring down poverty, unemployment and inequality in the developing countries. In fact the paradigm led to large scale displacement and environmental degradation in the name of development (Melkote and Steeves, 2015) and key aspects of development processes- emancipation and empowerment - were not explicitly stated in the modernisation paradigm (Sinha 2013).

Jan Servaes (1986) points towards the dichotomy of 'traditional' and 'modern', inherent in the modernisation paradigm, which has restricted it to having uni-linear and evolutionary perspectives founded on the concepts of economic growth only. The modernists identified 'growth' as the idea of 'progress and underestimated socio-psychological attitudes, nationality, strengths of traditional systems etc. The minimalistic approach of modernisation and its limits were identified by the theorists of this paradigm also and Rogers, Lerner and others who later modified the central ideas by addressing the 'individuals' and the cultural environment in which communication strategies needed to be evolved.

These debates paved the way for Dependency Theory.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

- 1) What is the role of mass media in development according to modernisation theorists?

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- 2) What is the criticism of modernisation approach to development?

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16.3 THEORIES SINCE DOMINANT PARADIGM OF DEVELOPMENT

Structuralist and dependency theories were proposed as a response and critique of the dominant paradigm of development. These theories reaffirmed the significance of the international social and political system in the course of development within each nation. Issues of economic development could not be understood on a nation- by-nation basis and an analysis of the network of interrelations among nations must be evaluated according to these theories.

16.3.1 Structuralist Theory

The key aspects of structuralist school of thought were proposed by Raul Prebisch, first executive director of Economic Commission for Latin America (ECLA) and Brazilian economist Celso Furtado. They broadly divided the world into Core nations and Periphery nations and articulated the unequal terms of trade that exist between core and periphery nations, they cited the experiences of Latin American nations such as Chile. Breaking away from this unequal trade relation requires rapid development through fast-paced industrialisation. The Structuralists argued that the only way Third World countries can develop is through action by the state. They need to push industrialisation and reduce their dependence on trade with the First World, and trade among themselves.

Structuralism focuses on policy prescriptions including major government intervention in the economy to fuel the industrial sector, known as Import Substitution Industrialization (ISI). ISI is the initiative for ending the reliance of the underdeveloped country on exports of primary goods such as agricultural and mining products. It shields the domestic economy from that of the developed economies. The under-developed economy is protected by the trade barriers and promotion of domestic industrial substitutes.

16.3.2 Dependency Theory

Dependency theory was proposed as a response to the failure of Latin American structuralism. It was influenced by the works of Paul Baran (The political economy of growth) and Andre Gunder Frank (Capitalism and underdevelopment in Latin America) which were based on the US monopoly capital School of thought. It critiqued the exploitation of periphery (underdeveloped countries) by the core (developed countries) and extraction and transfer of surplus generated in the periphery nations. It also critically viewed the collapse of ISI in periphery nations.

The main theorists of Dependency School of thought were Gunder Frank, Fernando H. Cardoso, Samir Amin and Immanuel Wallenstein. According to

Gunder Frank the ties of dominance and dependency run in chain- like fashion throughout the global capitalist system with, 'metropolitan states'(centre) appropriate the surplus from the 'satellites'(periphery). While the Structuralists were of the view that, development would not be possible unless a strategy for delinking with other developed economies is put in place and rigorous ISI was pursued, dependency theorists allowed developmental interaction with other parts of the globe.

According to dependency theorists:-

- Economic growth in developed nations did not lead to growth in the poor countries, whereas activities in richer countries often lead to serious economic problems in the poor countries.
- Poor countries exported primary commodities to the rich countries and they manufactured products out of those commodities and sold them back to poor countries.
- Poor countries should be empowered themselves on import substitution practice.
- Replace imports to capital products.
- Levy higher tariff for capital goods.
- Import substitution is not a feasible solution as this increased dependency on foreign capital goods (machine tools and technology).
- New forms of marginalisation from labour intensive structures to capital intensive structures emerged. (Indebtedness)
- Politics became more authoritarian.
- Undevelopment v/s underdevelopment: - Undevelopment refers to a condition which resources are not being used while underdevelopment refers to a situation in which resources are being actively used but used in a way which benefits dominant states and not the poor states.

Instead of internal factors such as traditions and values, dependency theorists (Santos, 1971; Galtung 1971) attributed 'historical conditions which favoured the developed west' as the cause for underdevelopment of the third world. Immanuel Wallerstein, (2000) identified two interdependent regions of the world as labour- intensive production based periphery and capital- intensive production based core. According to them, technology was the most prominent factor which shaped up the core and periphery nations.

Dependency paradigm was strongly influenced by the Marxist way of social interpretations. According to Servaes, this notion failed to recognise the local inequalities and class differences. However, dependency and world-systems analysis showed that independence from western colonial forces alone had not sanctioned freedom to the South as those nations were largely dependent on the foreign policies of North, markets, capital and technology (Mody, 1991).

Based on the critique of modernisation, structuralist and dependency theories; some Alternative approaches to development emerged.

Mass communication theories are classified in various ways. This is because theories or the way social processes are explained keep changing or advancing depending on technological, political and social factors. Most mass media theorists

classify theories based on eras of development of mass media. And rightly so, because the way the media operated in society and the importance they held from time to time changed with the change in technology. So while theories are generally classified as those of the era of mass society, the era of scientific perspective, the era of limited effects and the era of cultural theory, to facilitate greater understanding, we classify them as sociological, psychological, critical and cultural theories and media society theories.

16.4 ALTERNATIVE APPROACHES TO DEVELOPMENT

Alternative approaches to development placed individuals above society, allowed plurality in development discourses and brought participation, equality and inclusivity as keys to development. It underscored the importance of meeting basic needs of the 'last' person of society and the need to curb unscrupulous exploitation of natural resources. Some of these include basic needs approach, another development paradigm, participatory approach, capability as development and rights based approach. Let us discuss these approaches in detail.

16.4.1 Basic Needs Approach

The Basic needs approach is rooted within the ideas of well being and focuses upon the fulfillment of basic human needs of people as the overriding objective of any development policy. People who are unable to meet their basic human requirements are living in poverty. The approach included identifying and measuring wellbeing outcomes and focused upon standards of both material needs, such as food, clothing shelter as well as non-material needs such as employment, participation and political liberty. The approach was proposed by Paul Streeten and others. The main features of this approach were:

- Provide adequate food and clean drinking water
- Provide decent shelter
- Provide education
- Provide security of livelihood
- Help people participate in decision making
- Uphold a person's dignity and self respect.

PQLI (Physical Quality of Life Index): The usual indicators of development such as GDP and GNP did not adequately reflect growth in the quality of life of an individual. In order to measure the fulfillment of standards in a quantifiable way, one measure/indicator developed by Overseas Development Council (ODC) was the PQLI which includes data on three aspects:-

- Life expectancy
- Infant mortality
- Literacy

Flexibility and ease of implementation is the core strength of this approach. Based on prevailing situations different bundles of needs can be created for different regions or groups of people. However it remains a top down approach and is

criticised for its arbitrariness as “Experts” and policy makers generally decide peoples ‘needs’, assuming that all people have exactly the same needs and are indifferent to individual preferences.

16.4.2 Another Development Paradigm

Jan Servaes (1986) postulated a new paradigm - ‘multiplicity’ or ‘another development’, which stated, ‘development must be conceived as an integral, multi-dimensional and dialectic process which can differ from country to country’.

He observed that each country should form their own model of development by keeping in mind the factors such as basic needs, endogeny (stemming from the heart of each society), self-reliance, ecological balance, participatory democracy and structural transformations.

The alternative paradigm of development rejects the idea of economic centralism in development discussions. It puts both social and cultural aspects of the society as vital components of development. The scholars associated with this approach are Jan Servaes, Majid Teharanian and Goran Hedebo. The new definitions for development under alternative paradigms included clean environment, growth with equity, provisions for basic needs such as food, shelter, education and medical care, meaningful employment and a harmonious relationship between culture and change.

The key elements of alternative paradigm or new paradigm are:-

- Greater equality in the distribution of growth
- People’s participation
- Self reliance and independence
- Integration of traditional and modern communication systems
- Acceptance of local culture.
- Peng Hwa Ang and Shikha Dalmia (2000) traced inherent contradictions and inconsistencies in the multiplicity paradigm and posed some relevant questions. What would be the outcome if the history and culture of a society contradicted any of the principles of the paradigm? What would happen if an under developed country relied heavily on its own culture in the absence of any other model? Is the new paradigm free from paternalism (i.e., when the administrative machinery does everything for its citizens, but not giving any choice at all)? The authors concluded that the multiplicity paradigm also was not successful in providing a theoretical framework for development in many developing countries.

16.4.3 Participatory Approach

The participatory approach, on the other hand, places people at the core of development processes. It incorporates the concepts in the framework of multiplicity and stresses the significance of cultural identity of local communities, democratisation, peoples’ participation at all levels. It emphasises emancipatory processes that strive towards redistribution of power and greater voice to the marginalised. Braidotti et al (1994) called for “locally sustainable lifestyles, participatory democracy and recovery of dominated people’s over powered

knowledge”. They summarised the alternative perspectives on development as:

- Equity in of information and other benefits of development
- Active distribution participation of the people at the grassroots
- Independence of local communities (or nations) to tailor development projects to their own objectives.

Integration of the old and new ideas, the traditional and modern system, the endogenous and exogenous elements to constitute a unique blend suited to the needs of a particular community.

Building empathy and communion participatory processes help shape new ideas, foster trust and encourage people to question existing hierarchies.

The importance of dialogue and participation was ascertained by many other scholars as well. Well known usages such as “making them (people in the periphery) masters of their own destiny” (Wang and Dissanayake, 1984), “development with a human face” and “growth with equity” gained much attention in the participatory approach to development.

‘Equality’ and ‘access’ constitute two key intertwined facets on which effectiveness of the participatory model depends. The first emphasising respect and dignity for otherness and opportunities for collective dialogue rooted in Freire’s dialogical pedagogy. The second involves the opportunities of access, participation and self-management (Berrigan, 1977, 1979) in bottom up decision-making within organisations and in the formulation of policies and plans.

However, later experiences revealed that these were not sufficient to answer the complex issues of development emerging in the 21st century. Although people may have chances to access development initiatives, but their ‘capability’ to utilise such opportunities made a difference.

16.4.4 ‘Capability’ as Development

According to Nobel laureate Amartya Sen (2000), the notion of defining development in terms of Gross National Product (GNP), Gross Domestic Product (GDP), industrial output etc. was considered only as ‘means’ of well- being but this did not guarantee freedom to individuals. The concept of freedom encompassed better education and health care, removal of poverty and hunger, political and civil rights which contributed to development and quality of life. He observed that even in economically well-developed regions; conditions of lack of freedom and subsequent under-development co-existed for long. Thus ‘development as freedom’ according to Sen can be achieved only by creating an atmosphere where people have the opportunity to manifest their capabilities. He defined ‘capability’ as an individual’s freedom to achieve various lifestyles’.

Sen’s proposition on development did not disregard the economic growth perspectives in a monolithic way. He extended the argument for development further by focusing on communities within communities and individuals within families. He correlated conditions of ‘unfreedom’ to lack of development and ascertained the importance of creating a conducive atmosphere for maximising the human potential or capability to achieve real development. He did not propose a model which can be replicated everywhere but pointed out the inter-relationships

of variables such as economic growth, poverty, under development, support led-strategies, public action and freedom and reaffirmed the importance of evolving region- specific development strategies (Dreze and Sen, 1996).

Thus in the capability approach, poverty is seen in terms of deprivation of ‘basic capabilities’ when people are not able to achieve crucially important functionings, such as being nourished and being sheltered. Unlike the needs approach which is a consumption oriented approach, the capabilities approach is a people-focused approach. It focuses on enhancing people’s well being by expanding their capabilities so that they can look after themselves and lead the life they value. It is a holistic approach and connects the problem of poverty with the broader issue of human development. It advocates empowerment initiatives that emphasise people’s participation and development programmes that provide opportunities and choices that enable greater control over their lives.

16.4.5 Rights Based Approach

Human rights are the basic rights and freedoms to which all humans are entitled. Historically, recognition of rights has guaranteed minorities and various groups of people to challenge power structures and enjoy entitlements denied to them. First generation rights have protected Civil and political liberties; Second generation Economic Social and Cultural rights have led to greater tolerance to religious and cultural practices. The Right to Development, a third generation right is regarded as an inalienable human right which all peoples are entitled to participate in, contribute to, and enjoy economic, social, cultural and political development. It is considered as a key element for achieving development goals.

Lately, with globalisation and rising inequities the voices for ‘inclusive development’ and rights based approach have gained currency in the policy formulations of national government’s Right to Information, Right to Employment, Right to Food and Right to Education were fully or partially implemented or enacted in the country. In this approach, the focus is on ‘distributive equity’ where individuals are empowered legally to claim their rights and fruits of development.

The right to development contains specific entitlements that include:

- People-centred development- identifies “the human person” as the central subject, participant and beneficiary of development.
- A human rights-based approach - requires that development be carried out in a manner “in which all human rights and fundamental freedoms can be fully realised.
- Participation - calls for the “active, free and meaningful participation of people in development.
- Equity- the need for “the fair distribution of the benefits of development.
- Non-discrimination - permits “no distinction as to race, sex, language or religion.
- Self-determination- integration of self-determination, including full sovereignty over natural resources, as a constituent element of the right to development.

It can be observed that Millennium Development Goals (2000) and Sustainable Development Goals (2015) set out by the UN for its member states have linkages with the rights based approach of development.

Poverty reduction, elimination of hunger, health care, gender equality and environmental sustainability were some of the eight Millennium Development Goals targeted to achieve before 2015, by all UN member countries. However, the MDG targets established by the United Nations in 2000 for the member states failed to achieve the desired results in parts of the globe, particularly in Africa. In 2015, September UN set out 17 Sustainable Development Goals which included targets 169 which are to be fulfilled before 2030 as an agenda for global development. The crux of these initiatives is to ensure inclusion of the most disadvantaged people in the process of development.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What are the key features of structuralist and dependency theories?

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2) Trace the salient features of another development paradigm.

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16.5 APPROACHES TO DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION

The scholarship on the role of communication in development has undergone paradigmatic changes along with the changes in the approach to development. Development communications, initially was characterised by the use of mass media and people were considered passive audiences ready to be influenced by the messages they received.

Dominated by western notions of development and westernisation, communication was rooted in the basic Sender-Message-Channel-Receiver (SMCR) model and was perceived as a simple one-way asymmetrical process. The top-down, vertical communication models of the dominant paradigm was challenged by inter-dependency theorists who called for decolonisation of information conditions in the developing countries. This approach has helped in

institutionalising “New World Information Order” (Narula, 2014). Further, the dependency theorists pointed out that the control over mass media by transnational corporations has enabled the promotion of consumerism which led to cultural imbalances. According to them, mass media should take up the role of an educator and help them in mobilising their own structure for development.

Subsequently, the Basic needs approach was promoted by Paul Streeten et al (1979) which was aimed at creating awareness among the poor people about their fundamental needs such as food, clean drinking water, shelter, education, livelihood etc. and ways to achieve these minimum requirements. It sought the government intervention in establishing community media networks to help poor people who were denied access to mass media due to various socio-economic factors. By placing the audience who were ‘active’ and ‘participatory’ at the centre, the New Paradigm of Development in the 70’s proposed a two-way communication for development between authorities and audience. Bottom-up interactive communication strategy was adopted in this period.

Paulo Friere, Luis Ramiro Beltran and Arturo Escobar; scholars from Latin America, enriched the participatory model of development and communication by exposing the discriminatory approaches in the western models (Sinha, 2013). Friere through his famous work, ‘Pedagogy of the Oppressed’, revealed the tendency to promote dependence among underprivileged communities by the dominant institutions in the name of ‘assistencialism’ (providing assistance to make them dependent always). Escobar explored the issues related to ‘capital’ based development strategies and how it aggravated the unequal conditions of development in the developing countries. The Latin American school of thoughts sought rejection of the ‘transmission models’ mooted by the west by the participatory model and ‘dialogic communications’.

Under the participatory approach, with increased emphasis on horizontal communication processes, the focus shifted to motivating the community to participate in dialogue and evolve their own development strategies. The importance of the process and context was emphasised in the exchange of ‘meaning,’ and the effect ‘of’ as well ‘on’ patterns of social relationships and social institutions due to the participatory processes. The emerging alternative communication paradigm favoured multiplicity, smallness of scale, locality, de-institutionalisation, interchange of sender-receiver roles (and) horizontality of communication links at all levels of society (McQuail, 1983:97).

During the 80’s, specific efforts were made to bring development to the needy through an approach known as Information, Education, Communication within cultural matrix and Motivation for participation in development (IECM). Mass media had a pivotal role in each of these stages. Globalisation and economic reforms introduced yet another approach - technology paradigm in which decentralisation, participatory democracy and sustainability featured prominently.

Milan L. Rodrigo (1989) highlighted agriculture, irrigation, health education and family planning as four areas associated with top-down models of development communication. After explaining the limitations of the economic (Rostow), modernisation (Lerner) and diffusion (Rogers) approaches of development communication, she called for a receiver-centered, bottom-up approach. She emphasised popular participation and facilitation of personal expression and dialogue and said, ‘for any development programme to be

successful, it has to be integrated and coordinated with the needs of the people. It must also be implemented by committed leaders'. The lack of insight and understanding in development planners of the needs of their clients were identified as the major factor for setbacks in achieving desired goals of development.

The basic framework of communication for development hence has seen some drastic shifts from a simplistic one-way, asymmetrical approach that was used to influence, less developed third world countries, to adhere to Western ideas and norms to a more mature sophisticated, two-way symmetrical approach that aims to involve the target audience through various means of participation. The conceptual shifts in the concept of development have consequently led to transformation in the role of media and development communications. You will read more about it in the next unit.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What is the nature of communication in the modernisation paradigm?

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2) Briefly outline the shifts in the framework of Communication for Development.

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16.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed the changing concept of development through the emerging theories of development. The Modernisation or dominant paradigm of development aimed at replicating the western model of development and Mass Media was considered a strong agent in bringing about socio-economic change. It was criticised for its economic growth oriented linear top down approach and was later replaced by the structuralist and dependency theories. These theories focused on underdeveloped countries which need to reduce their dependence on the developed world to overcome their vulnerabilities.

We further discussed Alternative approaches to development including another development paradigm and participatory approaches that recognised the multiplicity of perspectives and need for center-staging marginalised groups,

voices in development debates. The basic needs approach focused on the fulfillment of human needs, and the 'capability' as development brought to light the issue of freedom, capability and choices while the rights based approach provided an entitlement view towards development. In the last section we highlighted how through various conceptual changes in the notion of development the role of communications for development has changed and evolved.

From above discussion you would have learned that there is no universal approach for developing a region. Ideally, it should be evolved from respective regions as per the needs and aspirations of the people and it also should facilitate in improving the quality of life in terms of socio-economic and cultural growth of individuals. Development experiences in the present context need introspection in terms of inclusion, equality and freedom and the role of media in current development discourse.

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16.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The powerful effects of mass media in disseminating information and its capability in bringing about desirable changes was the foundational pillar of modernisation theorists. Media was portrayed as magic and mobility multipliers which can act as an agent in creating 'empathy among masses'. Media was perceived as the supporter of development initiatives in this school of thought.

- 2) Modernisation approaches underestimate the ground realities of least developed nations. The technology and innovation provided were not tailor made for the regions. It undermined the ethnic culture and ignored the characteristics of communities. The economic imbalance created out of modernisation was instrumental in increasing inequality in such societies. Further, it forced the periphery nations dependent on foreign capital intensive technology and structures and thereby paved the way for neo- economic colonialism which was based on exploitation.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) The structuralist theory prescribed fast-paced industrialisation based on indigenous technology as a panacea for under-development. They advised shielding of the domestic economy through Import Substitution Industrialisation. The reliance of periphery nations on core nations should be brought down according to structuralists. Dependency theorists were more realistic about the inadequacies of indigenous technologies for industrialised nations and advised need based imports of capital goods.
- 2) Another development paradigm brought in human face to development discourses. Equality and participation were considered as key drivers of development according to the theorists. They accepted local culture and sought a mid-way between tradition and modernity.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) The dominant paradigm was characterised by the use of mass media and people were considered passive audiences ready to be influenced by the messages they received. Communication was rooted in the basic Sender-Message-Channel-Receiver (SMCR) model and was perceived as a simple one-way asymmetrical process and remained top-down and vertical in approach.
- 2) The basic framework of communication for development has seen some drastic shifts from a simplistic one-way, asymmetrical approach that was used to influence, less developed third world countries, to adhere to the Western ideas and norms to a more mature sophisticated, two-way symmetrical approach that aims to involve the target audience through various means of participation.

UNIT 17 PERSPECTIVE OF DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION

Structure

- 17.0 Introduction
- 17.1 Learning Outcomes
- 17.2 Approaches to Development
- 17.3 Concept of Development Communication
 - 17.3.1 Definitions
 - 17.3.2 Philosophy
 - 17.3.3 Features
- 17.4 Media and Development Communications
 - 17.4.1 Mass Media
 - 17.4.2 Alternative Media
 - 17.4.3 Traditional Media
- 17.5 Development Communication and New Technologies
- 17.6 Peoples' Participation and Development Communication
 - 17.6.1 Participatory Communication
 - 17.6.2 Participatory Democracy
 - 17.6.3 Policy Formulation and Citizen's Participation
- 17.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 17.8 References and Further Readings
- 17.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

17.0 INTRODUCTION

You have read about the evolution of the field of Development Communication in the previous unit. Development communication is the process of deploying communication as a catalyst of social change aimed at improving the lives of the poor in sustainable ways. Since its inception, the field of Development Communication pertains to a process of strategic intervention through various forms of mass media and interpersonal methods of socio-cultural engagement.

The focus of Development Communication approaches has since shifted from a top down, government propaganda and aid agency jargon to strategies for deepening democracies, encouraging peoples' participation and sharpening approaches for bottom-up decision making. These shifts emerged and the focus changed from a predominantly economic growth-driven model of development to a participatory model in which social and cultural factors play an important role.

Development Communication today deals with concerns of inclusive growth in developing countries, where millions of people face abject poverty and deprivation. The subject area is as much about our understanding of development priorities as it is about communication needs for a better and less unequal world. In this unit, we shall discuss various pertinent issues relating to the concept of

17.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through the unit, you should be able to:

- differentiate between different perspectives of development and the role of Development Communication;
- explain the concept of Development Communication;
- describe the elements and philosophy of Development Communication;
- explain the role of Media in Development;
- discuss the scope of ICTs as a tool of empowerment; and
- describe mechanisms of people's participation and the role of participatory communication in inclusive growth.

17.2 APPROACHES TO DEVELOPMENT

The country's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth continues to be a buzzword in news stories and is treated as synonymous with a nation's development. However, this is contested by a large number of practitioners and development thinkers and the inadequacy of economic indicators like GDP, Gross National Product (GNP). They argue that social indicators such as the Human Development Index (HDI), Physical quality of the life index (PQLI), Multidimensional Poverty index (MPI), are better measures of a country's development and the well-being of its people.

The expanded concept of development perceives it to be a multidimensional process leading to the improvement in both economic and social conditions of a country. Current notion of development also emphasises enhancement of people's freedoms, capabilities and entitlements for a better life. Thus apart from basic problems of underdevelopment (Poverty, Health, Hunger, Food security, Illiteracy, Unemployment etc.) that continue to plague most of the less developed countries including India, issues of social inclusion, equitable growth and social justice have become the focus of the development agenda and consequently the focus and role of Development Communication.

Inclusive growth and Social justice

Development Communication tackles development issues in ways that can help the poor people lead a life of dignity and equal opportunities. Promoting inclusive economic growth is the new model that is related to providing equality and opportunity to all, for achieving a productive and meaningful life with freedom, equality and dignity. Through its initiatives, Development Communication promotes core values of a socially just society that encourages basic human rights, equitable distribution of resources, equal opportunities, peace and security and the realisation of human potential.

Development policies hence need to address issues of social and economic challenges and the multiple deprivations faced by the poor and marginalised groups.

Mainstream Gender and Marginalised Communities

One of the biggest challenges of Development Communication is to mainstream gender and marginalised communities. Poverty exacerbates inequalities which further leads to worsening of poverty and backwardness. Further under-development of the marginalised and gender inequality is correlated. Women of India continue to face multiple deprivations and form one of the most neglected, poorest segments of the population. The same can be said about the marginalised communities like the dalit, tribal and various backward communities. With limited or poor access to education, healthcare, employment, communication and other services they remain enmeshed in the multiple webs of poverty.

Sustainable economic growth and human development rest on equal participation of women and the marginalised sections of society. Development policy, issues of governance as well as development planning need to be looked at from the perspective of inclusion and exclusion. Providing them a greater voice and prioritising the needs of the economically and culturally vulnerable is key to their societal mainstreaming and our nation's development.

Environment Sustainability

Development communication also plays a key role in reinforcing the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and its principle of environmental sustainability and spearheading processes for empowering people to act and deal with the environmental challenges communities are facing. Any successful endeavour will require amalgamation of traditional and scientific knowledge, debate on policy and programmes, and collaboration between governments, corporates and civil society at the national and global levels.

Institution Building

Strengthening capacities of development professionals and building institutional infrastructure of organisations involved in development is necessary to enable effectiveness of development delivery and efficiency in utilisation of development aid. Development Communication supports the building of strong vibrant institutions, facilitating freedom of expression in which all groups are able to voice opinions and participate in development debates. An independent media that serves the public interest; enables transparency and accountability in development programmes and involves divergent stakeholders in debates are a key thrust area of Development Communication.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

- 1) How are HDI-based indicators different from GDP growth rate based markers of development?

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- 2) What are the key aspects of the current development paradigm?

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17.3 CONCEPT OF DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION

Let us now examine the term ‘Development Communication’. Several scholars have provided definitions of Development Communication that vary in their perspectives. These definitions not only help to understand the boundaries that define the field of development communication but also better comprehend how it has expanded in its nature and scope.

17.3.1 Definitions

One of the earliest definitions was provided by Nora Quebral. According to her (1975), “development communication is the art and science of human communication applied to the speedy transformation of a country and the mass of its people from poverty to a dynamic state of economic growth that makes possible greater social equality and the larger fulfillment of the human potential.”

Quebral highlights the importance of development communication for not just informing and persuading people to adopt new ideas and technologies but also understanding the root cause of people’s problems, inequality and marginalisation that they face. These insights need to be combined with the theory and practice of communication for creatively developing appropriate programmes and media strategy for alleviating poverty and improving people’s quality of life.

According to Everett Rogers (1983) “development communication refers to the uses to which communication is put in order to further development. Such applications are intended to either further development in a general way, such as by increasing the level of the mass media exposure among a nation’s citizens, in order to create a favourable ‘climate for development, or to support a specific development programme or project (this type of development communication is often termed as ‘development-support communication’ DSC”).

Rogers, in his Diffusion theory focused upon the application of communication for the purpose of disseminating information and messages to induce change. The flow of information (mostly one-way), helps create a suitable environment by providing relevant information and effective messages for persuading people to adopt new ideas or innovations at a fast pace.

F. Rosario Braid is of the opinion that development communication is “an element of the management process and the overall planning and implementation of development programmes”. And in a broad sense, “the identification and utilisation of appropriate expertise in the development process that will assist in increasing participation of intended beneficiaries at the grassroots level.” While

Erskine Childers in her definition said “Development support communications is a discipline in development planning and implementation in which more adequate account is taken of human behavioural factors in the design of development projects and their objectives”. Thus, development communication plays a key role in engaging people and understanding their varied perspectives and ideas. Incorporating people’s viewpoints in the various processes of development projects enables projects to become more people-centric, leading to greater receptivity towards new ideas, ownership of projects and their consequent success.

In 1997, through Article 6 of General Assembly Resolution 51/172, the United Nations adopted the following definition “Communication for development stresses the need to support two-way communication systems that enable dialogue and that allow communities to speak out, express their aspirations and concerns and participate in the decisions that relate to their development”. The Rome Consensus of the First World Congress of Communication for Development (WCCD), held in Rome in October 2006 defined it as: “a social process based on dialogue using a broad range of tools and methods. It is also about seeking change at different levels, including listening, building trust, sharing knowledge and skills, building policies, debating and learning for sustained and meaningful change. It is not public relations or corporate communications”.

These definitions focus not only upon the participatory nature of development communication but also on its transactional nature and the opportunities that need to be created for people to freely articulate their ideas and dialogue about issues most relevant to them. Focusing upon both the socio-cultural context as well as people’s capacities; they draw attention to the diverse factors that can influence integration of multiple voices in development programmes and policies and action towards sustainable change.

From above definitions you would have understood that development communication does not merely involve the transmission of information about products, ideas and or facilities for improving peoples’ lives, or the exchange of information for problem-solving. It extends to include developing empathy for others, raising aspirations, building new skills and capacities as well as increasing peoples’ participation in development activities. Interweaving both mass media and interpersonal communication systems, development communication helps people to understand the linkages between local events and national and global issues; develop new perspectives as well as nurture relationships between different stakeholders groups, for effective management of development activities and realising the full benefits of development.

17.3.2 Philosophy

Communication for Development differs from other forms of communication, such as corporate and internal communications. Corporate communication helps to build organisational identity and communicate organisational values, mission and activities consistently to the public. Internal communication on the other hand is the flow of information within an organisation and enables timely and effective communications among staff for greater coordination, work efficiency and outputs. Development Communication is a specialised field different from others because of the role it plays in empowerment processes. It strives towards sustainable change by involving different stakeholders, establishing a conducive

environment and using appropriate media and methods for inducing behaviour and social change.

Development Communication can be further differentiated from other fields by three aspects, i.e. it is Purposive, one looks for specific behavioural objectives; Positive, affirmative prosocial values are attached to what one communicates about; and Pragmatic, practical and having specific purpose, it is evaluated by the results achieved (Jamias, 1975). For example as a Development communicator, one looks for specific behavioural objectives, such as adoption of a high yielding variety of seeds by farmers. This can increase their harvest manifold and hence has a definite positive value attached to it. The development communicator plans interventions knowing well that mere increase in the flow of information does not necessarily result in behavioural changes desired. The intervention efficacy is later revaluated by examining what were the objectives, the intended results, what led to the success/failure of the communication. In this regard, feedback is taken from different stakeholders and not merely by the communication activities performed, such as the number of posters printed or visits made and so on:

Activity 1

In your community look for at least two posters/hoardings put up by any government agency. Analyse the message and state if it is Purposive, Positive and Pragmatic

17.3.3 Features

From above analysis, the following features of Development Communication emerge:

Communication is vital for human growth and progress and use of Communication for Development makes a difference to human development.

Development Communication is an essential part of programmes and initiatives aimed at achieving development goals as well as those challenging existing hierarchies and power structures for achieving development priorities in an equitable and sustainable manner.

Participation is fundamental to processes of development communication and enables multiplicity of voices, especially of the poor and marginalised, to be incorporated in development programmes and policy.

Dialogic processes are central to development and empowerment practices. Based on horizontal, two-way processes, Development Communication prioritises communication systems and processes sensitive to the local context, that enable people to deliberate and speak out on issues important to their own well-being.

Development Communication helps create a constructive environment where stakeholders participate in defining problems, arrive at a common understanding of issues, consider and discuss ideas, negotiate, and collectively find solutions.

- Development communication processes include, among other things, analysing the socio-economic and political context of communities, identifying and prioritising needs, assessing risks and opportunities, empowering people and strengthening institutions.

- Development Communication utilises multiple communication methods and media, which include Interpersonal communication, Mass media, ICTs etc, for information dissemination, behaviour change, social mobilisation, advocacy for sustainable social change.
- Development communication encourages advocacy to build networks and collectives to influence policy formulations.

The two primary roles Development Communication plays are - transforming role and socialising role.

Transforming role: As it seeks pro-social change in the direction of improving the quality of life of people. Promoting immunisation of children and institutional deliveries of pregnant women, encouraging enrollment of girls in schools, adoption of toilets by families, breaking myths surrounding menstruation or social customs like early marriage are some initiatives for improving the lives of people with communication being an integral component for achieving these objectives.

Socialising role: By seeking to maintain some of the established values of the society, development communication seeks to create an atmosphere for change as well as providing innovation through which society may change. Each society has some traditional values that give people an identity, a sense of belonging and within which their aspirations are intricately embedded. As people of different cultures meet, the values, customs and beliefs of societies make inroads into each other's societies, slowly influencing and changing them. Communication can play a very vital role by making people aware of differing values and beliefs, critically examine new ideas as well as re-analyse the relevance and richness of their own values, customs, beliefs and, above all, aspirations in changing contexts.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Define development communication.

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2) How is Development Communication different from other types of communication?

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- 3) What types of communication media and methods does Development Communication use?

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- 4) What processes are central to Development Communication initiatives?

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Activity 2

Analyse the socialising and transforming roles of any programme being implemented in your area for women or adolescent girls drawing upon points discussed above.

17.4 MEDIA AND DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATIONS

As the concept of development communication has evolved with time, consequently the nature of communications and the role of media have also changed focus. Earlier it was expected to convey all the relevant information regarding a development programme and the benefits that may be reaped by the community. Media was expected to build a favourable climate to implement such programmes by removing doubts, apprehensions or fears about them. Development communications was characterised by the use of mass media that considered people as passive audiences ready to be influenced by the messages they received, and was simple one-way asymmetrical communication (Mefalopulous, 2008). Later the focus of Development Communication moved from a 'communicator' to a more 'receiver-centric' orientation. Advocating 'bottom up' two-way symmetrical approaches it recognises and adopts various participatory methods for inclusion and active participation of the target audience. The emphasis of Development Communication processes has shifted from persuasion to information exchange; from information transmitted to the meaning sought and attributed by audience groups; and disseminating information for which there is a need than creating a need for the information being disseminated.

17.4.1 Mass Media

Mass media as you are aware play a significant role in taking development to the people. Being able to reach a large number of heterogeneous audiences scattered over vast geographical areas, their ability to provide the same messages

simultaneously to a vast and diversified audience remains unparalleled. They have a definite role in spreading information about development, making people aware of their rights and responsibilities, exposing anomalies and corrupt practices, and promoting transparency and accountability through encouraging participation in development schemes. By not only reporting facts about specialised areas of development, it also strives to provide an interpretation and analysis.

Communication interventions for development are made through various media platforms such as the newspapers magazines, radio, TV, Internet or movies and theatres etc. In a country like India, where literacy level is low, the choice of mass media is of vital importance, as they reach out to different groups of audiences. The Satellite Instructional Television Experiment (SITE, 1975-76) was one of the earliest projects primarily undertaken to develop special development programmes through satellite communication. Later the Kheda Communication Project, the Indian National Satellite project (INSAT) (1982); Educational programmes (ETV) Gyan-Darshan Educational Channel (2000); E-Choupal and others have demonstrated the potential of using mass media for development.

The mass media has played a particularly positive role in enlightening farmers on the use of various technologies to boost agricultural development; Women programmes cover a range of subjects related to empowerment of women as well as programmes on a range of topics like health, sanitation, family planning, education, conduct of democratic exercises like free and fair elections and monitoring of expenditure or implementation of development plans are some areas media has focused upon.

17.4.2 Alternative Media

Recent years have seen the emergence of a range of alternative, participatory media forms that are separate from and provide an alternative to commercial media as well as state-run public-service media. Also called 'community media,' 'citizen's media,' 'grassroot journalism' it has created local alternatives to mainstream broadcasting like local community newspapers, radio stations, as well as traditional media such as theatre and puppetry. Differing from mainstream media in their aesthetics, independent non-profit orientation, non-dominant discourse and serving the needs and interests of a community it enables people's participation and their greater access and control of the media and communications in their community. Contesting and challenging mainstream media discourses, community media aids in raising people's awareness, representation and the consequent emergence and democratisation of an alternative public sphere. Some of the most successful alternative media for development are community radio, community video, and community newspapers. You will read in detail about alternative media in Unit 16 of this course.

17.4.3 Traditional Media

Traditional cultural forms such as peoples' theatre, puppets, song and dance are also being designed to engage people and communities in positive social change. Sensitive to the needs and context of the communities, folk media are an integral part of the fabric of rural communities. Social ideas, tradition and culture are preserved and disseminated through these highly intimate, flexible and dynamic,

traditional media forms. Enjoying immense popularity and appeal they have traditionally been used for entertainment, social communication and persuasive communication. Now, several initiatives have involved folk media for conveying development messages. By presenting messages subtly in local popular artistic forms, they carry the message of development among the masses.

Indian People Theatre Association (IPTA), used some of the popular regional theatre forms like “Jaatra” of Bengal, “Bhavai” of Gujrat, “Tamasha” of Maharashtra and “Burkatha” of Andhra Pradesh to increase social awareness and political education. Other initiatives include the Kerala Sastra Sahithya Parishad (KSSP) which organised Science Jathas, a science procession using different folk art forms to spread the message of people’s involvement in the development process. The International Planned Parenthood Federation and UNESCO used traditional media for promoting family planning. Folk songs have played a very important in the Chipko and Narmada movements. Organisations like Katkatha for puppetry, Jan Sanskriti, Sahmat and several theatre groups are using the traditional media innovatively for spreading messages to both urban and rural audiences.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) How has the role of media changed in Development Communication?

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2) What are the characteristics that distinguish community media from mainstream media?

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Activity- 3

In your community, identify development messages being given through two different media forms. Are these messages reaching the target groups? Analyse.

17.5 DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION AND NEW TECHNOLOGIES

The new communication technologies such as the Internet, ICT, mobile phones and satellites have radically transformed the concept and nature of development as well as communication. In today's information societies, communication networks occupy a central place. The way citizens connect with each other depends on their access and use of these technologies.

These technologies enable fast exchange of information and overcome time and space barriers and have immense potential for providing effective solutions to various problems. Many countries have evolved technology-enabled systems to make development programmes more effective. Enabling real time information about projects technologies is leading to better monitoring of projects and decision making, disbursement of benefits and targeted deliveries of goods and services to the poor. The system of grievance redressal is leading to reduction in corruption and is making development both transparent and accountable. E-governance initiatives seek to provide essential services, such as providing drinking water, healthcare, power supply and civic amenities, to the citizens in ways that are simple, speedy and inclusive.

Apart from being cheap and user-friendly the use of new technologies also offers varied opportunities for two-way communication to people to voice their ideas and access relevant information. Farmers get weather or market-related information on their mobile phones, ASHA workers get alerts about monitoring pregnant women's health, beneficiaries receive SMS when money or entitlements are transferred in their accounts, data regarding government schemes on websites is helping minimise corruption. These concepts are giving new directions to the very idea of development communication leading to empowerment of citizens.

Technology and Digital Divide

It is true that the digital divide separates the 'digital haves and have-nots'. People with higher levels of education and prosperity are able to make better use of ICT and knowledge products than those who are less privileged. The divide works as a roadblock for use of technologies for removal of poverty and inequality. The access to digital technology goes a long way in providing benefits to the users in terms of skills, knowledge, capabilities and consequently incomes, increases the divide further. Hence, one of the biggest challenges of development communication is to work towards enabling the digital have-nots to access ICT and digital services.

Differences in the availability, access and use of these technologies pose several challenges. In India, with a large section of the population not being technology literate, users need training in basic computer use as well as skills to communicate effectively on the Internet. Gender and socio-cultural differences impede the availability and use of ICTs by several community groups. Several researchers have pointed out that how ICTs are embedded and utilised within specific local contexts and needs will determine their effectiveness as instruments of social change.

Further, the new technologies are also seen to be dominated by vested interests and market-driven forces that are leading to hi-tech systems becoming tools of exclusion rather than inclusion.

However, despite such limitations, ICTs can and do play a major role in development communication. Apart from being used for information dissemination, technologies also have the potential to support horizontal communication processes. Technologies such as IVR systems, Mobile apps, low power technologies used by community radio and participatory video are proving to be powerful instruments in promoting people's participation and empowerment.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) In what ways are new media technologies transformative?

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2) What are the challenges of using ICTs for rural communities?

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Activity 4

Give four examples of digital divide from your surroundings

17.6 PEOPLES' PARTICIPATION AND DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION

We have discussed in the previous section that people's participation is central to Development Communication. It is recognised that inclusive development cannot be achieved without involvement of community in various stages of development projects. However, people's participation is known to range from tokenism to proactive involvement and is deeply linked to prevailing power (im)balances, empowerment and equality within communities. Often a misinterpreted concept, significant and meaningful participation requires the application of two-way participatory communication processes.

17.6.1 Participatory Communication

A dynamic, interactional, and transformative process, participatory communication enables people to articulate their ideas, recognise common concerns, and seek solutions from within their community. By generating an open environment, participatory processes enable stakeholders to engage in

dialogic processes, build trust and confidence among each other. Consequently they lead to raising awareness about critical issues, improving access to information, increase utilisation of services, mobilise people around a common issue and encourage them to engage in their own and their communities' development (Singhal, 2003). All participatory communication activities ultimately endeavour to encourage certain changes in attitude or behaviour at the individual, family, and/or community levels.

Underpinning participatory communication is the idea of providing communication rights for ordinary citizens. Providing a voice to the voiceless they stress the need to create alternate communication spaces for the poor and the marginalised that strengthen the diversity of cultures and languages in ways not provided by the conventional media. The movement for communication rights was spearheaded by the UNESCO and the MacBride Commission through its report (1980), *Many Voices, One World*. The Commission highlighted the problems of commercialisation of media, unequal access to information and communication and of a rising communication deficit in the developing and under-developed countries. The commission called for democratisation of communication and this became the basis of many community media projects throughout the world including the community radio movement in India.

17.6.2 Participatory Democracy

Participation is strongly related to the power dynamics in decision making. Letting the poor and marginalised make strategic decisions about programmes and policies influencing their lives involves devolution of power. The 73rd and 74th Amendments of the Indian Constitution provide a participatory framework by giving powers to panchayats and urban local bodies and subsequently for people being in-charge of development of their areas. A significant aspect of these provisions is planning by people through locally constituted District Planning Committees (DPCs) who consolidate and implement plans prepared by the village panchayats and urban municipalities. The success or failure of these plans, and thereby the future of development depends significantly on the citizens' awareness levels and participation through effective communication strategies.

Another very important aspect of participatory development is the community monitoring of development schemes. The MG-NREGS has the objective of providing rural employment, and enhancing livelihood security. The scheme also has the provision that the Gram Panchayat holds regular social audits of all development works by making available all relevant documents to the gram sabha.

17.6.3 Policy Formulation and Citizens' Participation

The task of creating awareness and promoting citizen participation in policy formulation is one of the new challenges of development communication. There is a near absence of institutional mechanisms for ordinary citizens to intervene in the processes of legislations or policy making, and policy making continues to be treated as a matter of expert knowledge, mostly left to the 'specialist' and not something which can be shared with ordinary citizens.

The inclusion of ordinary people in policy formulation has become all the more important in the post-liberalisation era when the state has retreated from some key areas in the economy leaving space for the private sector or Public Private

Partnerships. It is in this backdrop that the citizens' participation is required to check the possibility of the policy process being dominated by powerful vested interest groups and has direct bearing on inclusive development.

Check Your Progress 5

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Define Participatory Communication.

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2) Why is it important for the citizens to engage with the Policy formulation process?

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Activity- 5

Identify a news item reported in the national and local newspaper about your city/town/area. Do you think there is a difference in what is presented in the two newspapers? How would you like the content to be presented?

17.7 LET US SUM UP

It was explained in this unit that the concept and meaning of both development and communication are undergoing rapid changes in the modern world. We also discussed that high GDP-growth rate cannot be equated with inclusive growth and top-down, economic growth driven models of development are giving way for culturally sensitive participatory models. Thus, the focus of development communication has shifted to more inclusive and participatory development to include the marginalised and vulnerable sections of society.

Various definitions expanded the scope of development communication to include developing empathy for others, raising aspirations, building new skills and capacities as well as increasing people's participation in development activities. Its role in empowerment and philosophical foundations of being positive, purposive and pragmatic enable the understanding of the various aspects of Development Communications.

Development Communication utilises multiple media, which include mass media, community media and ICTs, for information dissemination, behaviour change,

social mobilisation, advocacy for sustainable social change. A key aspect of development communication is promoting peoples' participation and providing them greater voice through participatory communications. Consequently it strives to improve citizens' awareness and engagement with governance and demanding greater transparency and accountability in development processes and policy making.

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17.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) Social indicators like the HDI, PQLI, and MPI are better indicators of a country's development and the wellbeing of its citizens. HDI indicators recognise that GDP growth rate is not synonymous to a nation's development. To measure development, they account for both social upliftment and economic growth.
- 2) Current notion of development emphasises enhancement of people's freedoms, capabilities and entitlements for a better life. In addition to poverty, health risks, food insecurity, illiteracy, etc. that continue to plague the less developed countries, issues of social inclusion, equitable growth and social justice have become the focus of the development agenda.

Check Your Progress – 2

- 1) Development Communication, apart from sharing of information to improve people's lives, extends to developing empathy for others, raising aspirations, building new skills and capacities as well as increasing people's participation in development activities.
- 2) Development Communication is a specialised field differing from other communications because of its role in empowerment processes. It strives towards sustainable change by involving different stakeholders, establishing a conducive environment and uses appropriate media and methods for inducing behaviour and social change.

- 3) Development Communication utilises multiple communication methods and media, which include IPC, mass media, ICTs, etc., for information dissemination, behaviour change, social mobilisation, advocacy for sustainable social change.
- 4) DevComm stands on three philosophical ideas: it is Purposive, one looks for specific behavioural objectives; Positive, affirmative pro-social values are attached to what one communicates about; and Pragmatic, practical and having specific purpose, it is evaluated by the results achieved.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Earlier, the media was expected to build a favourable climate i.e. to convey all the relevant information regarding development programmes and their benefits. The advent of participatory approach led to increased emphasis on horizontal communication processes, and people dialoguing to evolve their own development strategies. The alternative communication paradigm favours multiplicity, smallness of scale, locality, and decentralisation.
- 2) Community media differs from mainstream media in their aesthetics, independent non-profit orientation, non-dominant discourse. It serves the needs and interests of a community, and enables people's participation and their greater access and control of the media and communication in their community.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) The emerging new technologies such as the ICTs, mobile phones have radically transformed development and communication. Communication networks occupy a central place; the way citizens connect with each other depends on their access and use of these technologies. Enabling fast exchange of information and overcoming time and space barriers, these technologies have immense potential for providing effective solutions to problems faced by people.
- 2) Digital divide separates the "digital haves and have-nots". There is a need to work towards enabling the digital have-nots to access ICT and digital services. People with higher levels of education and prosperity easily use ICT and knowledge products than those who are less educated and go a long way in providing the benefits to the users.

Check Your Progress: 5

- 1) Participatory communication is a dynamic, interactional, and transformative process, that enables people to articulate their ideas, recognise common concerns, and seek solutions from within their community.
- 2) Policymaking largely remains a matter of specialised knowledge; best left to the 'experts' and is often not shared with ordinary citizens. It is in the interest of inclusive development that ordinary people engage in policy formulation.

UNIT 18 INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS AND TEAM BUILDING

Structure

- 18.0 Introduction
- 18.1 Learning Outcomes
- 18.2 Interpersonal Communication
 - 18.2.1 What is Interpersonal Communication?
 - 18.2.2 Basic Elements in Interpersonal Communication
 - 18.2.3 Barriers to Interpersonal Communication
 - 18.2.4 Merits of Interpersonal Communication
- 18.3 Interpersonal Communication Skills
 - 18.3.1 Listening
 - 18.3.2 Interpersonal Communication is Participatory
- 18.4 Concept of Team
 - 18.4.1 Types of Team
- 18.5 Team Development
 - 18.5.1 Team Building
- 18.6 Team Effectiveness
- 18.7 Let us Sum up
- 18.8 Keywords
- 18.9 References and Further Readings
- 18.10 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

18.0 INTRODUCTION

In this unit we aim at understanding communication from the three perspectives of interpersonal, group and mass communication levels.

The unit presents various skills required to communicate at interpersonal level such as speech, listening, use of language etc

18.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to :

- discuss the concept of team;
- identify various types of team;
- describe the process of team development;
- explain the team building process; and
- analyse the effectiveness of team;

18.2 INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION

18.2.1 What is Interpersonal Communication ?

Interpersonal communication is communication between two persons or between one person and a group. When communication takes place between two persons it is called Dyadic communication. Interpersonal communication is direct and not mediated by media technology. Interpersonal communication is needed for the maintenance and development of personal relationships as well as social systems. It is difficult to think of any social group functioning as a unit or group without interpersonal communication. A community or group is not merely an assortment of individuals, but a cohesive unit. It gets a sense of unity and identity as a result of communication. Relationships are created and maintained by interpersonal communication.

18.2.2 Basic Elements in Interpersonal Communication

Interpersonal communication may be verbal or non-verbal. In this process, both the sender and receiver are aware of the process of interaction by which messages are sent and received. We may identify two kinds of interpersonal communication -transaction and interaction. By transaction we mean private taUc between friends, family members, lovers etc. This kind of communication is more informal and does not need to conform to public or social rules. In interaction, on the other hand, people relate to each other within the framework of certain established norms and rules of behaviour. These include social etiquette, religious or social norms that govern conduct, speech etc. Most relationships begin with interaction and move on to the level of transaction.

In interpersonal communication the process of sending and receiving takes place almost simultaneously, so it is not always easy to say when a person is sending or when one is receiving a message. For instance, the one who is talking to another individual or a group besides sending messages, searches for the reaction of his audience. He adjusts the message according to the feedback he is getting from his listeners. If the listener is seen to be bored or disinterested, the speaker may skip some portions of what he wants to say, or change topics or stop speaking altogether.

The one who communicates must constantly adjust his or her message according to the reactions of the listeners-attention, ability to grasp, approval. He or she must constantly monitor the facial expressions, gestures, sounds etc. of his audience. In interpersonal communication, there is constant interaction and both the parties speak or communicate. The interpersonal communication process is flexible. For instance, a grandmother who tells tales or sings lullabies to put a child to sleep. The grandmother stops the story or the song even before it is completed, if she sees the child has already fallen asleep.

We receive most of the information about ourselves and other people through interpersonal communication. The amount of information we receive and its value will depend on the degree of our willingness to enter into communication with others and our willingness to share information with them. Interpersonal communication involves choices. It calls for making decisions. We can communicate or choose to ignore persons or groups we encounter.

For instance, in travelling in a railway compartment, we may be in the midst of strangers. We may travel a long distance without any communication, or we may strike up a conversation, and then begin to build relationships by means of interpersonal communication. Many of our acquaintances and friends are the result of efforts we have made or willingness we have shown in order to enter into interpersonal communication.

Interpersonal communication calls for skills in order to interact effectively with others. Knowledge of social norms and behaviour and etiquette, ability and willingness to listen, concern and respect for one another, willingness to share about oneself etc. are also important components which make for successful interpersonal communication.

18.2.3 Barriers to Interpersonal Communication

There can be several barriers that block interpersonal communication. These include social or cultural prejudices, superiority- inferiority complexes that affect people because of religious affiliation, cultural notions about oneself, economic status, ethnic identity. In India the caste system and caste hierarchy can prevent effective interpersonal communication between people belonging to different caste categories. Even though such barriers block effective communication, interpersonal communication can be used as an effective means to overcome social differences.

Cultural biases constitute another barrier in interpersonal communication.

The idea of racial superiority promoted by Hitler led to the killing of millions of Jews.

Social barriers include prejudices against women, discrimination against the socially marginalized, the economically disadvantaged etc.

Barriers in communication also include communication gaps due to differences of age, mentality, and attitudes; lack of communication between married partners, members of a family etc. These can lead to boredom, frustration, loneliness, dejection and other personality complexes. Failure to interact effectively at the interpersonal level leads a person to be withdrawn, cut off from society. More aggressive forms of such maladjustment can even lead to violent behaviour, suicide etc.

Success in interpersonal communication would mean overcoming these and other barriers. It involves both partners in the process.

Inability to communicate effectively on the interpersonal level is the root cause of many social and family disorders.

Effective interpersonal relationships can build a family and community, build up social cohesion. Effective social communication equips individuals and groups with what David Riesman refers to as “internal radar”: which enables one to adopt and adjoin oneself to fit into society.

18.2.4 Merits of Interpersonal Communication

One of the benefits of interpersonal communication is that it establishes and sustains our social moorings. When people communicate with each other

effectively, they find others with whom they can associate. They develop identities, such as friends, lovers, colleagues, bosses, neighbours, family members.

- Interpersonal communication helps people fit into society and receive acceptance, thus getting rid of loneliness and boredom.
- It assists in accomplishing one's goals with others. Interpersonal Communication may serve as the ground for cooperation and collaboration in achieving what we want our goals.
- It helps people to identify and follow rules of social interaction.

Our society is governed by rules. Violation of rules or our inability to follow social norms may lead to rejection and isolation.

Interpersonal communication calls for skills. Skills can be acquired or learned. The ability to acquire skills and to become proficient in their use depends on several factors such as:

- Drives and needs, rewards and reinforcement,
- Perceptive and cognitive faculties, aptitudes, attitudes and environment,
- Personality of the individual: Psychological, Biological factors,
- Sociological factors,
- Learning abilities of the individual motivation and willingness to learn.

18.3 INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Speech, Language

Though the origin of human speech remains obscure, with reasonable certainty we can assume that human beings were born with an instinct of speech. Vocal communication has been a significant step in the history of human civilization. The development of language, through its primitive form and over several centuries, contributed substantially to enhance the process of interpersonal communication.

In order to use communication effectively, one needs to have effective speaking skills. Oratory or rhetoric, mastery of language and effective use of vocabulary, which form important elements in communication, can be acquired by learning and perfected by practice.

Body Language: In some cultures people use their hands and face a lot to convey messages. The body language or gestures are important in order to keep the attention of the receiver. A magician or puppeteer or a clown in a circus shows how body language is an important component in effective interpersonal communication.

Identification with people, empathy and understanding: Interpersonal communication can become a very creative form of reaching out to others by bringing comfort to people, alleviating their sorrow or suffering, helping them overcome loneliness and boredom. The counsellors, religious leaders, relief workers and sometimes media persons who visit people in adverse circumstances as in an accident or natural disaster do this.

18.3.1 Listening

Interpersonal communication involves two or more individuals and it provides a congenial atmosphere for communication. It should be two way, interactive, and mutual. Listening is an essential element of such communication. Though listening is an important element in communication, this skill is often neglected in training programmes in communication skills.

Listening skills can be developed by means of training.

Listening is more than just hearing the words of the speaker, but trying to grasp the meaning. Meanings are constructed by the listener, and this calls for paying attention to factors like: gestures, facial expression, silences or pauses, voice modulation etc.

Listening can improve the performance of families, industry, business etc. In a company where the supervisors and managers are poor listeners, there can be many problems. Effective listening can reduce tension, conflict, and improve the morale and motivation of the staff.

18.3.2 Interpersonal Communication is Participatory

Interpersonal communication is participatory. The chances of communication breakdown are much less as the communication partners are face to face and the words and symbols are picked up and interpreted in the presence of each other. The feedback is instantaneous as expressed in the form of body language or verbal assent or dissent.

Subir Ghosh narrates how in the days before microphones came into use, Gandhiji addressed vast multitudes in open spaces where the people in the front conveyed his words to those sitting or standing behind them. Gandhi chose his words and timed them so as to help this process. It was extremely effective because it involved receivers of the message in the act of communication.

In spite of the rapid progress in the information and communication technology (ICT), the most powerful and persuasive, the most effective means of communication continues to be the one in which an individual speaks to another. Recent developments in teleconferencing and electronic chat or widespread use of mobile and cellular phones are only limited expressions of the warm, intimate, personal communication.

Interpersonal communication can also be used to build cooperation and resolve conflicts. Many of the social conflicts today can be traced back to poor knowledge of others - be they members of a family, religious group, political party or other social organisation. Conflict resolution and promotion of peace can be effected through interpersonal communication. In international relations and global efforts to resolve conflicts between nations, the process of interpersonal communication is being used effectively today. Persons representing the governments or the countries or other organisations, need good communication skills in bringing about the desired results.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What is interpersonal communication?

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2) Mention some of the merits of interpersonal communication.

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3) What are the barriers to interpersonal communication ?

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4) How is listening important in interpersonal communication ?

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18.4 CONCEPT AND TYPES OF TEAM

If you visit an organisation, you will find that most of the activities of the organisation are performed by a group of persons. In an organisation, activities are arranged in such a way that require collective contribution. Every individual contributes for the achievement of a common goal. The individuals interact, collaborate, coordinate and influence among the members. Thus, most of the time individuals work in a team. A team may be defined as a group of two or more people who interact and influence the members for the achievement of

common goals. Steven and Mary Ann Von have defined the team as groups of two or more people who interact and influence each other, are mutually accountable for achieving common objectives, and perceive themselves as a social entity within an organisation. Based on this definition, the characteristics of the teams may be elaborated as under :

- a group of two or more persons
- regular interactions among members
- influence the behaviour of team members
- mutually accountable
- interdependent
- social entity
- achievement of common goal

The frequency of interactions, influence and the nature of task may determine the formation of a group, i.e., long-term, short-term, formal, informal etc.

18.4.1 Types of Team

Formal teams or groups are created deliberately by managers carrying out specific tasks to help the organisation achieve its goals. The most prevalent type of formal group is the command team, which includes a manager and all employees who report to that manager. In some organisations that want to deemphasize hierarchy, the titles may change.

Another type of formal team is the committee, which generally lasts a long time and deals with recurrent problems and decisions. For instance, your university or college probably has a committee for student affairs to deal with recurring issues that involve students' lives. While members of this committee may come and go, the committee remains in place over time.

A quality circle is a kind of team. At Reynolds Metal Company's McCook Sheet & Plate Plant, based in McCook, Illinois, quality circles have been a significant component of a quality programme that has dramatically improved productivity and quality since 1981. In a programme called Cooperative Hourly and Management Problem Solving (CHAMPS), quality circle teams meet for an hour weekly to discuss work related problems, investigate the causes, recommend solutions, and take corrective action. When a team has completed its investigation and identified a solution, it makes a formal presentation to the plant management and staff. Of the almost 475 solutions offered in the first four years of the programme, almost 400 were approved. The total savings from the ideas has been eight times their cost, a significant amount in a major manufacturing facility where cost control is very important. Over a three-year period, McCook was able to double the pounds of aluminum per employee that it shipped and deliver more than 2,000 items to a specific customer without a single rejection.

Some formal teams are temporary. They may be called task forces or project teams. These teams are created to deal with a specific problem and are usually disbanded when the task is completed or the problem is solved.

Informal teams or groups emerge whenever people come together and interact regularly. Such groups develop within the formal organisational structure.

Members of informal teams tend to subordinate some of their individual needs to those of the team as a whole. In return, the team supports and protects them. The activities of informal teams may further the interests of the organisation. Saturday morning games, for example, may strengthen the players' ties to each other. Or a women's group may meet to discuss various actions that can make the organisation a better place for women to work.

For example in 1990, female employees at the telephone giant, NYNEX Corporation, formed mentoring circles to assist women in moving up the corporate advancement ladder. NYNEX women created these informal groups independently and outside management auspices. The groups encourage, recognize, and strengthen the bonds of women at all levels of the company. The NYNEX employees turned to the group format because there was a shortage of female upper-level managers to serve as mentors. However, participants believe the group process is actually better than individual mentoring. In the circles, which have a minimum of eight participants and a maximum of twelve, the mentored women have an increased exposure to different ideas and an increased network. You have already learnt about various types of team in unit 12.

18.5 TEAM DEVELOPMENT AND BUILDING A TEAM

As you have already learnt that the team is formed as a result of interactions and influence of members who strive for the achievement of common goals. In this process, the team members try to understand others behaviour, realise the appropriateness of the behaviour and the roles of the team members. This is an ongoing process because the composition of the team may keep on changing. The new members may join and the old members may leave the team. Thus, the team members pass through several stages for the development of the team. Bruce Truckman has identified five stage models of team development. You have already learnt this process in unit 12. Let us learn them briefly :

Forming : This is the first stage of team development. In this stage the members try to explore and understand the behaviour of the team members. They make their efforts in understanding the expectations of the team members. At this stage they are polite and try to find out how to fit into the team.

Storming : In the second stage, members start competing for status, leadership and control in the group. Individuals understand others behaviour and assert their role in the group. As a result inter-personal conflict starts. Members try to resolve the issues related to the task and working relations. They also resolve the issues related to the role of the individual in the group.

Norming : The members start moving in a cohesive manner. They establish a balance among various conflicting forces. They develop group norms and consensus for the achievement of the group goal. At this stage, cooperative feelings develop among the team members.

Performing : In this stage, the team makes effort for the performance of task and accomplishment of objectives. The established pattern of relationships improves coordination and helps in resolving conflicts. Members trust each other and extend their full cooperation for the achievement of the group goal.

Adjourning : As you must be aware that the team is formed for some purpose. When this purpose is fulfilled, the team may be adjourned. Thus, the breaking up of the team is referred to adjournment.

Kormanski and Mozenter have identified following stages of team development:

- Awareness
- Conflict
- Cooperation
- Productivity, and
- Separation

18.5.1 Team Building

Team building refers to shaping of the team for smooth functioning. Steven and Mary Ann Von have defined team building as any formal intervention directed toward improving the development and functioning of a work team. Thus, the process of team building aims at enhancing the effectiveness of a team. Pareek Uday has suggested following approaches for team building.

The Johari Window Approach : This approach aims at helping members to express their feelings, opinions, reactions and accept feedback from team members. This enhances their sensitivity towards the team members.

The Role Negotiation Approach : This approach focuses on understanding the expectations of the team members and accommodating their behaviour according to the expectations. This enhances the collaborative effort of the team members.

The Team Roles Approach : This approach advocates that there are certain roles which each team members are expected to perform. Belbin has identified eight roles. They are : Chairman/coordinator, shaper, plant, monitor/evaluator, company worker, resource investigator, team worker and completer/finisher. Smooth performance of these roles brings harmony in the effort of the team members.

The Behaviour Modification Approach : This approach focuses on examining members behaviour towards the team. The individual member evaluates his/her own behaviour and finds out the most suitable behaviour. Now he/she adopts the most suitable behaviour for the performance of the team.

The Simulation Approach : In this approach an artificial team is formed where members interact, discuss, deliberate and learn from other members' behaviour. In this situation, the team members learn the most effective way of dealing with the challenges and meet the requirements and the expectations of the team members.

The Action Research Approach : In this approach, the whole range of behaviour is analysed and evaluated. The researcher interacts with the team members and evaluates their behaviour. The effort is made to find out the most suitable behaviour of the team members.

The Appreciative Inquiry Approach : This approach focuses on the identification of positive qualities in the team members. The effort is made to

channelise these positive qualities towards the achievements of the team goal.

Pareek Udai has integrated the above approaches and further suggested following approaches for team building which are discussed below :

Projection into Future : In this approach, the team members prepare a common vision of the team. Several small teams may prepare their own vision which may be further developed as a broader organisational vision. The team members may be encouraged to make an effort towards realising them.

Linkage with Individual Goals : As you must be aware that the building block of the team is individual. Each person has his/her individual goal as well as team goal. Therefore, the individual goal must be integrated with the team goal. This brings harmony in the team effort and enhances the performance of the team.

Force Field Analysis : Several forces influence the performance of the team. Team members are required to analyse these forces and identify the positive forces. These favourable forces are channelised for the achievement of the team goal.

Strengthening Positive Forces : The positive forces are identified and further reinforced. The reinforcement of behaviour motivates the members for making efforts towards the realisation of team goals. This further strengthens the positive behaviour of the team members.

Reducing Negative Forces : In this approach, the forces which inhibit the performance of the team are identified. The efforts are made to remove these negative forces.

Monitoring : The team members chalk out detailed plans and targets to be achieved. The mechanisms for achieving these targets are spelt out. The steps are devised to monitor them at each step. The proper monitoring mechanism facilitates the process of accomplishment of team goals.

While building the team, the managers must take into account those factors which contribute to effective accomplishment of the team goals. The integrated view of the above approaches may provide better insights for enhancing the effectiveness of the team.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the spaces given below for your answers.

2) Check your answer with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Distinguish between formal team and informal team.

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- 2) Distinguish between storming and norming.

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- 3) Enumerate five most suitable processes for team building.

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18.6 TEAM EFFECTIVENESS

In an organisation, you may find that some teams are more successful and work effectively than others. The question arises what is team effectiveness? Steven and Mary Ann Von have defined team effectiveness as the extent to which the team achieves its objectives, achieves the needs and objectives of its members and sustains itself over time. This means that the effective team has following parameters:

- The degree to which the objectives of the team are achieved;
- The degree to which the team achieves the needs and well being of its members; and
- The ability of the team to survive

Steven and Mary Ann Von have suggested following elements of team effectiveness:

- 1) Organisational and Team Environment : Organisational and team environment relates to the following elements:
 - Reward System
 - Communication
 - Systems
 - Physical Space
 - Organisational Environment
 - Organisational Structure, and
 - Organisational Leadership
- 2) Team Design : It involves following elements:
 - Task Characteristics
 - Team Size; and

- Team Composition
- 3) Team Processes : It includes:
 - Team Development
 - Team Norms
 - Team Roles; and
 - Team Cohesiveness

Kormasnski and Mozenter have identified following elements which contribute to team effectiveness:

- Members understand and are committed to group goals;
- They are friendly, concerned and interested in others;
- They acknowledge and confront conflicts openly;
- They listen to others and understand them;
- They involve others in the process of decision making;
- They recognize and respect individual differences;
- They contribute ideas and solutions;
- They value ideas and contributions of others;
- They recognize and reward team efforts; and
- They encourage and appreciate comments about team performance.

These are the major elements contributing to the team effectiveness. Moreover, there may be several factors which influence the team effectiveness. Managers are required to make detailed analysis of these factors and find out broader perspectives of the team effectiveness. The proper management and implementation of these elements may certainly improve the effectiveness of the team.

18.7 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we have learnt the basic definition of interpersonal communication, and its characteristics. As well as we have learnt the various skill sets are required to be effective communicators. Then we focussed on the team building processes, more particularly the various types of team formation, and role of communication in the process of team building. If you relate these two concepts - interpersonal communication and team building process - you probably be able to connect the effectiveness of communication in the success of managing a small team of people.

18.8 KEYWORDS

Team: Two or more people who interact with and influence each other toward common purpose.

Team Building: A conscious effort to develop effective work groups throughout an organisation.

Dyadic: Communication between two persons.

Interpersonal: Between two or more persons in communication.

Body language: Use of bodily gestures other than words to enhance communication, such as gestures. In dance and folk art, there are assigned meanings for certain body movements and signs.

18.9 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

Mc Quail's Mass Communication Theory

https://books.google.co.in/books/about/interpersonal_relationships_E_Book.html?id=XC2GDwAAQBAJ&printsec=frontcover&source=kp_read_button&newbks=1&newbks_redir=1&redir_esc=y

<http://blog.schoox.com/interpersonal-communication-and-team-building/>

18.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS.

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Interpersonal communication is communication between two persons or between one person and a group. When communication is between two persons it is called Dyadic communication. Interpersonal communication is direct and not mediated by media technology.
- 2) Interpersonal communication helps develop identities, such as friends, lovers, colleagues, bosses, neighbors, family members. It helps people fit into society and receive acceptance, thus getting rid of loneliness and boredom. It assists in accomplishing one's goals with others. Interpersonal communication may serve as the ground for cooperation and collaboration in achieving what we want, our goals. It helps people to identify and follow rules of social interaction.
- 3) Barriers that block interpersonal communication include social or cultural prejudices, superiority-inferiority complexes that affect people because of religious affiliation, cultural notions about oneself, economic status, ethnic identity. In India the caste system and caste hierarchy can prevent effective interpersonal communication between people belonging to different caste categories. Barriers also include gaps due to differences of age, mentality, and attitudes; lack of communication between married partners, members of a family etc.
- 4) Listening is an important element in communication. Listening is more than just hearing the words of the speaker, but trying to grasp the meaning. Meanings are constructed by the listener, and this calls for paying attention to factors like: gestures, facial expression, silences or pauses, voice modulation etc. Effective listening can reduce tension, conflict, and improve the morale and motivation of the staff.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) **Informal:** Some formal teams are temporary. They may be called task forces or project teams. These teams are created to deal with a specific problem and are usually disbanded when the task is completed or the problem is solved.

Informal: Informal teams or groups emerge whenever people come together and interact regularly. Such groups develop within the formal organisational structure. Members of informal teams tend to subordinate some of their individual needs to those of the team as a whole. In return, the team supports and protects them. The activities of informal teams may further the interests of the organisation.

- 2) **Storming:** In the second stage, members start competing for status, leadership and control in the group. Individuals understand others behaviour and assert their role in the group. As a result inter-personal conflict starts. Members try to resolve the issues related to the task and working relations. They also resolve the issues related to the role of the individual in the group.

Norming: The members start moving in a cohesive manner. They establish a balance among various conflicting forces. They develop group norms and consensus for the achievement of the group goal. At this stage, cooperative feelings develop among the team members.

- 3) These are five most suitable processes of team building.

- a) **The Johari Window Approach:** This approach aims at helping members to express their feelings, opinions, reactions and accept feedback from team members. This enhances their sensitivity towards the team members.
- b) **The Role Negotiation Approach:** This approach focuses on understanding the expectations of the team members and accommodating their behaviour according to the expectations. This enhances the collaborative effort of the team members.
- c) **The Team Roles Approach:** This approach advocates that there are certain roles which each team members are expected to perform. Belbin has identified eight roles. They are : Chairman/coordinator, shaper, plant, monitor/evaluator, company worker, resource investigator, team worker and completer/finisher. Smooth performance of these roles brings harmony in the effort of the team members
- d) **The Action Research Approach:** In this approach, the whole range of behaviour is analysed and evaluated. The researcher interacts with the team members and evaluates their behaviour. The effort is made to find out the most suitable behaviour of the team members.
- e) **The Appreciative Inquiry Approach:** This approach focuses on the identification of positive qualities in the team members. The effort is made to channelise these positive qualities towards the achievements of the team goal.